

# Continuity in Kant's Philosophical Development

Harald Høffding

Translated from the Danish

*D. Kgl. Danske Vidensk. Selsk. Skr.*, 6. Series,  
Historical and Philosophical Section IV. 1. Copenhagen 1893

## Introduction

1. As is well known, Kant's principal work, the «Kritik der reinen Vernunft» [Critique of Pure Reason] (1781), was preceded by a long span of years in which the great ideas that were, through that work, to exert so vast an influence on the intellectual life of the following century slowly came to maturity. Kant has therefore often been cited as an example of late maturity. He was fifty-seven years old when the «Kritik der reinen Vernunft» appeared. But although his significance and fame are undoubtedly due above all to this work, it would nevertheless be mistaken to suppose that his preceding writings had value only as preparatory links in the history of his development and lost their significance once the principal work had come to light. Just as in their own time they earned Kant a highly respected name — so much so that on their account he was even ranked alongside Lessing, before he stood as the author of the «Kritik der reinen Vernunft» — so too do they to this very day offer more than a merely historical interest. They contain thoughts whose time is not past. Many of these thoughts Kant — in part with metamorphoses conditioned by his later standpoint — constantly retained and developed anew in his later works; it is chiefly with these that the present treatise will be concerned. But in the earlier works there are also thoughts that in the later works were wrongly cast into shadow or abandoned altogether. It was not in every respect an advance that Kant made when he reached his definitive standpoint. With regard to form in particular, the earlier works have a decided advantage. In them Kant appears as a clear and elegant writer, which he can by no means be said to be in all parts of his later works.

It was natural that the new, the grand, and the significant in the principal work should, both for Kant himself, his disciples, and his interpreters, cause the earlier works to recede into shadow. Only in recent years have they been brought forward again out of a purely historical interest. But this has then been done predominantly in order to trace the transitional links to the definitive standpoint. This study has — together with the Kantian manuscripts that in recent years have for the first time been brought to light — brought clarity to Kant's development in several respects, while at the same time, on certain points, it has proved impossible to reach any definite result. In this treatise I shall seek to illuminate some principal points in Kant's philosophical development, in such a way that I shall particularly establish the continuity in it and the enduring significance of much in the earlier works.

Kant himself, on various occasions, declared that his development had had definite turning points. In a letter to Mendelssohn of 18 August 1783 he writes of the manner in which the «Kritik der reinen Vernunft» had been composed: «What was the product of *at least twelve years of reflection* I had drafted in the course of four or five months.»<sup>1</sup> This statement points us back to the year 1769 as the moment of the inception of the train of thought that led directly to the «Kritik der reinen Vernunft». And with this agrees what Kant had written far earlier to Lambert (2 September 1770): «A year ago I attained, as I flatter myself, the concept that I do not fear ever having to alter, though I may have to extend it, and by which all sorts of metaphysical questions can be tested according to quite certain and easy criteria, so that it can be decided with certainty how far they are soluble or not.» In the notes of Kant that Benno Erdmann has published under the title «Kants Reflexionen», and which contain several interesting contributions to the history of his development, it is said, in a fragment that seems to belong to a draft of a projected preface to the «Kritik der reinen Vernunft»: «Aaret 1769 gav mig meget Lys» [The year 1769 gave me much light].<sup>2</sup> And when one of Kant's disciples wished to arrange a collection of his minor writings, Kant did not want works older than 1770 to be included in it (letter to Tieftrunk of 6 February 1798).

Here, then, we have a date for the beginning of the last period in Kant's inquiry, and a proof that he himself regarded it as a connected whole. A turning point in his development is established, and with it the task is posed — particularly when one wishes

---

<sup>1</sup>An entirely similar statement is already found in Kant's letter to Garve of 7 August 1783: «Den Vortrag der Materien, die ich *mehr als 12 Jahre hinter einander sorgfältig durchgedacht* hatte, ... brachte ich in etwa 4 bis 5 Monathen zu Stande.» (This letter is printed in Alb. Stern: *Ueber die Beziehungen Chr. Garve's zu Kant*, p. 33 ff.)

<sup>2</sup>*Reflexionen Kants zur kritischen Philosophie. Aus Kants handschriftlichen Aufzeichnungen herausgegeben von Benno Erdmann.* II. Leipzig 1884. p. 4. (No. 4.)

to show the continuity of the development — of explaining how this turning point was prepared by, and hangs together with, the preceding period.

Yet another problem Kant himself has set for those who occupy themselves with his development, by his reference to the debt he owed to David Hume. «I freely confess», it is said in the preface to the «Prolegomena», «that it was the recollection of David Hume which, many years ago, first interrupted my dogmatic slumber and gave my investigations in the field of speculative philosophy an entirely different direction.»<sup>3</sup> Here, then, reference is likewise made to an interruption, in that an impulse from without intervenes and brings about an entirely new direction in the work of thought. The question then becomes, first and foremost, at what point in Kant's development this awakening is to be placed. This question, despite all the learning and acumen that has been expended upon it, has not reached any unanimous answer among Kant scholars. There is no point at which there is such a leap in Kant's development of thought that a definite intervention of an alien train of thought would have to be regarded as an unavoidable assumption. Everywhere the progress can very well be explained as a continuation of the work of the preceding period. One of the most eminent Kant scholars has supposed that the year 1769, in which, by Kant's express declaration, the fundamental thought of his definitive philosophy arose, might also be the moment at which the awakening from dogmatic slumber came about.<sup>4</sup> It would indeed undeniably be the simplest thing if the two turning points mentioned by Kant himself coincided. Whether this is so can be decided only by a closer investigation of the change that took place in 1769. In itself there is no likelihood that the two moments coincide. An awakening is one thing, a discovery another; a new direction is one thing, a new result another. What happened in the year 1769 may have been an advance that became possible only because the awakening had gone before, perhaps long before. The light that dawned for Kant in that year he may have had to seek for a long time before he found it. And this is confirmed partly by the fact that in the letters to Garve and Mendelssohn he speaks of «*more than twelve years of work*», «*at least twelve years of work*», and partly by the fact that in the «Prolegomena» he states that the distinction he drew [in the «Dissertation» (1770)] between the elementary concepts of sensibility and of understanding succeeded only «*after long reflection*».<sup>5</sup>

It would, to be sure, be of no small interest if the moment of the awakening could be

---

<sup>3</sup>*Prolegomena zu jeder künftigen Metaphysik*. Riga 1783. p. 13.

<sup>4</sup>*Friederich Paulsen: Versuch einer Entwicklungsgeschichte der Kantischen Erkenntnistheorie*. Leipzig 1875. p. 126 ff.

<sup>5</sup>*Prolegomena zu jeder künftigen Metaphysik*. Riga 1783. p. 119.

determined with precision. The relation between Kant and Hume is a principal point in the whole history of modern philosophy. One might present this history as a great dialogue, in which Hume's rejoinder and Kant's answer to it stand as the most significant contributions. Both through the opposition between them and through the kinship between them, the study of their works is a source of ever-renewed orientation with respect to questions of philosophical principle. It would then be of great interest to learn at what point in his development Kant really and truly heard Hume's rejoinder. That it was not the moment when he first read Hume lies in his expression: «the *recollection* of David Hume». — It would likewise be of general psychological interest if this question could be more closely illuminated; we would thereby obtain a classic example of how a decisive influence can be received in an eminently independent manner.

But precisely in the difficulties bound up with establishing the moment of the awakening I see a proof of the continuity in Kant's development. Precisely because Kant's thinking was in constant unfolding — precisely because of his constant striving and tireless self-criticism (at any rate until the standpoint definitive for him had been reached) — it is difficult to decide when and how the external impulses, which on certain points are known to have been determining, intervened. — These remarks, moreover, apply not only to the influence of David Hume, but also to the influence Kant received from another great contemporary, one which, in the field of moral philosophy, intervened no less deeply in Kant's development than Hume's did in the field of epistemology — namely, that which came from Jean Jacques Rousseau. Neither would one have become aware of this had not utterances of Kant in that regard happened to be preserved.

The difficulty that has shown itself here often recurs in the investigation of a process of development, especially in the intellectual domain. To determine the exact relation between inner unfolding and external influence, where from the very first great forces are in motion, may easily become an insoluble task. Here it may often seem as if the inner unfolding could do everything, provided only it received favourable conditions, without any special external impulse being needed. So it goes with us precisely in the case of Hume's and Rousseau's influence on Kant; it is only the external testimonies that lead us to investigate it. Where Kant scholars disagree with one another, they therefore also employ in the debate the method of showing how the advance at the particular moment which the opposing party took to be the moment of the awakening can be understood without external influence. This method can be carried through all the more easily because, in the development of a significant mind, an influence will very often exert itself in an indirect way, in that it will consist more in the release of one's own

hitherto bound power than in a communication of material. What becomes the result of the awakening need not then resemble the awakening influence. The word by which one is awakened often has nothing at all to do with the deed to which one is awakened.

Although in what follows I occasionally permit myself a conjecture as to the moment of the awakening, I nevertheless attach the greatest interest to the dispute about it because it has strengthened the impression of the continuity in Kant's development. Kant himself, moreover, was likewise not of the opinion that his pre-critical writings should have entirely lost their significance. In a draft of a preface to the «Kritik der reinen Vernunft» he says: «By this treatise of mine the value of my earlier metaphysical writings is entirely annihilated. Only the *correctness of the idea* I shall still try to save.»<sup>6</sup> A kinship of thought is therefore acknowledged after all, despite the awakening and the turning point. It is this that is to be particularly treated in the present treatise.

For the sake of an overview I divide the exposition into four sections, in such a way that within each of these we investigate the relation between the earlier and the later standpoint with respect to a single definite point.

## I.

### The Concept of Cause

2. In Kant's student years his interest was taken up with Wolff's philosophy and Newton's physics. Toward both he adopted an independent position, which was a necessity for the very reason that there was a conflict between them, since Wolff still followed the Cartesian–Leibnizian physics and contested Newton's doctrine of attraction. This very conflict was bound to set reflection in motion, and we accordingly find, already in Kant's first independent period (1755–62),<sup>7</sup> attempts by him to alter his philosophical foundation in such a way that Newton's physics could come into its own. Kant did not stand alone in the Wolffian school with his recognition of Newton.<sup>8</sup> But he proceeded in a more independent manner than other Wolffians, and that not only toward Wolff but also toward Newton. In his famous youthful work «Allgemeine Naturgeschichte und Theorie

---

<sup>6</sup>*Reflexionen*. II, p. 5 (No. 7).

<sup>7</sup>Prior to this period there lie only a treatise on the estimation of living force (1747) and two short scientific essays (1754).

<sup>8</sup>Kant's teacher, *Martin Knutzen*, had already sought to combine Newton's physics with Wolff's philosophy, and he introduced his pupil to the study of both. Cf. *Benno Erdmann: Martin Knutzen und seine Zeit. Ein Beitrag zur Geschichte der Wolfischen Schule und insbesondere zur Entwicklungsgeschichte Kants*. Leipzig 1876. — In Denmark the Wolffian *Jens Kraft*, professor at Sorø, declared himself in his «Cosmologie» (Copenhagen 1752) against the Cartesian physics and for Newton's.

des Himmels» [Universal Natural History and Theory of the Heavens] (1755) he takes up the problem of the natural connection in the universe at the very point where Newton had not only abandoned it but had even declared it insoluble. Despite his great reverence for Newton, Kant could not rest content with his pronouncement that no natural cause could be given for the fact that the planets move around the sun in concentric orbits, in the same direction and roughly in the same plane, and that a corresponding state of affairs obtains with respect to the satellites. Kant regarded an appeal to a supernatural cause as unscientific, and attempted to show that the same law-governed order which now unites all bodies and elements into one great whole had also displayed itself at the origin of the world systems. This led him to his cosmogonic hypothesis, in which he sought to show that the origin of the solar system (and, by analogy, of other world systems) can be understood through the action of forces that are at work to this very day. It was the principle of actuality, the demand for a *vera causa* laid down by Newton, which he applied to what is distant in time, whereas Newton had applied it only to what is distant in space.

Kant's zeal to carry through a mechanical conception of nature is closely bound up with a philosophical train of thought that was already developing in him at that time. It was, he held, a false presupposition that one proceeded from when one supposed that nature, left to itself, would produce only disorder and chaos: not by chance, but in accordance with its own laws, nature produces what is purposive. And precisely the fact that the various elements thus work together from first to last and are encompassed by one and the same natural order testifies that in their essence and origin they are not independent of one another. The mechanical connection among all things in the world thus leads to the assumption of a unitary ground for all things. There are two conceptions to which Kant sets himself in opposition: on the one hand absolute atomism, which assumes mutually independent atoms that come to work together only by chance; on the other hand physico-theology, which assumes an external intervention of the Deity in the world-machinery. The three concepts element, law, and force he was unwilling to keep separated in an external manner.<sup>9</sup> This consideration became of importance especially with regard to the problem of the origin of the harmony and purposiveness found in the world. Kant complains that an almost universal prejudice has prepossessed most investigators against nature's capacity to produce anything ordered

---

<sup>9</sup>The intimate belonging-together of the concepts element and force is treated in particular in a treatise by Kant of the following year: *Monadologia physica* (1756), in which the atoms (i.e. the absolute atoms) are conceived as points of force, in a manner similar to that in which, in our own day, Fechner has conceived them in his «Atomenlehre».

by its own general laws. In his eyes it is precisely the order and harmony shown in what is produced according to nature's laws that bear witness that «the essences of all things have a common origin in one fundamental being». The common connection points to a common dependence. The more one comes to know nature, the more one is convinced that the things in the world, in their innermost essence, are not severed from one another and foreign to one another.

In this youthful work, then, Kant finds the connection between scientific knowledge and religious faith not by breaking through the connection which the former finds in nature, but precisely by proceeding from this connection. And he does not conceive teleology and mechanism as opposites, but demands that the purposive be explained as the fruit of a development according to general natural laws.

3. The same thought that Kant had applied in practice in his astronomical hypothesis he expressed at the same time in abstract form in his habilitation treatise on the principles of cognition.<sup>10</sup> He here calls it the *principle of coexistence*. If one wished — such is Kant's train of thought — to assume that the individual things (substances) in the world existed each by itself, independent of one another, one would not be able to infer from any single one of them the existence of the others. But this is not how things stand. By virtue of the mutual connection among all things in the world, one can draw inferences from one to another. This cannot be due to the mere coexistence of things, but must rest upon a community of origin, upon a common dependence on one and the same being. In the natural order itself, then, there lies a proof of a highest cause. This demonstration of a common source for all things in the world as the presupposition of the interaction according to general laws Kant believes himself to have been the first to give (*primus evidentissimis rationibus adstruxisse mihi videor*).

We stand here before a thought that Kant not only attached great importance to in his first works, but to which he later returned again and again, and which is characteristic of his manner of treating problems. Where Kant stands before a great principle (as here, for example, the mechanical conception of nature), he takes it in its full range and seeks either to show that on closer reflection it leads to quite different consequences than it seemed at first, or else that the whole sphere for which it holds does not express absolute reality but only one side of it. The first procedure he employs in his earlier period, the second in his later period. This procedure has a certain grandeur about it; it is advantageously distinguished from the so frequent halving of concepts and from the short-sightedness that would rather seek for itself a brief shelter in apparent exceptions

---

<sup>10</sup>*Principiorum primorum cognitionis metaphysicæ nova dilucidatio*. (Sämtl. Werke, ed. Rosenkranz and Schubert. I, p. 1–44.)

than resolutely think the principle through. But it also has its dangers, as Kant's own example will later show us.

4. Seven years after the habilitation treatise and the publication of the cosmogonic hypothesis, Kant took up the same train of thought that had animated them, in his work «Einzig möglicher Beweisgrund zu einer Demonstration des Daseins Gottes» [The Only Possible Argument in Support of a Demonstration of the Existence of God] (1762).

Here the critique of physico-theology, which had already been initiated in «Allgemeine Naturgeschichte und Theorie des Himmels», is carried out in more detail. Kant reproaches it for regarding the harmony and purposiveness in nature as accidental and therefore seeking a cause for them outside nature. It thereby becomes unscientific and has often hindered the advance of knowledge, in that usefulness and perfection were regarded as signs that the thing which possessed them had no natural origin, so that one refrained from all further inquiry. And even if one enters into the physico-theological train of thought, this nevertheless does not lead to what religious faith demands. For it explains only the ordering of the elements, not their origin. The Deity whose existence can be inferred along this line of thought thus becomes merely the architect of the world, not the world's absolute source.<sup>11</sup>

Nor do the other current proofs of God's existence find favour in Kant's eyes. Already in the habilitation treatise he had aligned himself with Crusius' critique of the ontological proof. Crusius had shown<sup>12</sup> that this proof, on which the preceding metaphysical systems (especially those of Descartes and Wolff) had laid so much weight, rested on a fallacy. Kant carries Crusius' critical train of thought further in a manner similar to that of the later, well-known development in the «Kritik der reinen Vernunft» of the difference between concept and existence. — Nor does he let the cosmological proof stand. An inference from the world given in experience cannot lead to the assumption of an absolutely necessary being.

The critique of natural theology that later, in the «Kritik der reinen Vernunft», caused such a great sensation, is thus already to be found in the «Beweisgrund». Were one to confine oneself to Kant's principal works, one would overlook the significant fact that several of the most important sections had come into being far earlier.

Yet in 1762 Kant had not given up every attempt at a theoretical grounding of natural

---

<sup>11</sup>It is of interest to note that Kant's critique of physico-theology dates already from 1755 and 1762. For in its main features it agrees with Hume's critique in his «Dialogues on natural religion», which appeared in 1779, two years before the «Kritik der reinen Vernunft» (although they had been composed many years earlier). Kant's independence thus stands firm. When he later came to know the «Dialogues», he set great store by them.

<sup>12</sup>Chr. Aug. Crusius: *Entwurf der nothwendigen Vernunft-Wahrheiten*. Leipzig 1745. § 235. (Cited here from the 3rd edition, 1766.)

theology. He does not, to be sure, regard proofs as necessary, since religious faith has another foundation than demonstration. But since he considers it valuable to test how far one can get along the path of reason, he sets up the following modification of the ontological proof: «All possibility presupposes something actual, in and through which everything thinkable is given. There is, then, an actuality by whose abolition all inner possibility as a whole would fall away. But that whose abolition or negation annihilates all possibility is absolutely necessary. Therefore there is something that exists with absolute necessity.»<sup>13</sup> This train of thought is not very clear, and Kant himself offers it not as a demonstration but only as a ground of proof, the only one he regards as possible. If it cannot lead to the goal, he says, then none can. — That it does not lead to the goal lies in the fact that, even though every possibility must have its ground in something actual, this actual thing need not itself be absolutely necessary; it may itself have its ground in another actual thing — and so on.

What chiefly interests Kant in this attempted recasting of the ontological proof is, however, that it would make possible a complete rounding-off of the train of thought familiar from his earlier writings, which led from the mechanical connection of nature to a unitary ground for all things. If each of the things in the world had its own separate necessity, it would be a matter of chance whether they fitted together in such a way that a whole could come out of them. For interaction to be possible, the things must from the very first constitute a system and all be dependent on a common ground. There must be a principle in which everything heterogeneous is connected, and in which all the manifold is in unity. This unitary ground, from which the first possibilities of things spring, must at the same time be the ground of all wisdom and goodness: only thereby does it become possible that the law-governed cooperation of things can accord with what wisdom and goodness demand.

This is the boldest swing that Kant's thinking has taken in a speculative direction. Far beyond the usual anthropomorphic concept of God, he seeks back to a foundation from which both the wisdom that proclaims itself in the world and the elements that cooperate in the world spring. In his zeal to draw the last consequence of the basic fact from which he proceeds — namely, the mechanical connection of nature and the inner connection it presupposes among all the elements of the world — his thought finally loses itself in a mystical abyss. Had he continued to dwell down there instead of returning to the daylight of rational consciousness, he would, in the twilight among

---

<sup>13</sup>*Einzig möglicher Beweisgrund zu einer Demonstration des Daseyns Gottes*. Königsberg 1763 [i.e. 1762]. p. 29. — This train of thought is already found in the habilitation treatise (Sectio II. Prop. 7), only in a more dogmatic form.

the few thinkers who moved there, have caught sight of Jakob Böhme and Spinoza. For when Kant, the first time he introduced the train of thought whose last consequence he here drew, had with self-assurance declared himself to be its first originator, this was not historically correct. In mystical form it is found in Böhme, and in clear connection with the mechanical conception of nature and as its consequence it is found in Spinoza, whose entire system is really a carrying-through of the thought that the causal connection is unintelligible when the individual things in the world are regarded as self-subsistent and independent beings (substances in the strictest sense). In his treatise «de emendatione intellectus» Spinoza sets up precisely the law-governed connection among phenomena as the basic fact from which thinking is to take its starting point. Spinoza's one substance corresponds to Kant's unitary ground. — Kant never knew Spinoza at first hand, and would surely have been highly astonished at the agreement into which he had come with the solitary thinker, for whom the time of understanding had not yet begun when Kant wrote his habilitation treatise and his «Beweisgrund».

In our own day two ingenious thinkers, in their effort to maintain an idealist conception of the world without compromising the consequences of the mechanical conception of nature, have developed a train of thought similar to that of which Kant believed himself to be the first originator. In the philosophical views of *Fechner* and *Lotze* it plays an important role. Lotze in particular has, in an acute manner, grounded his idealist monism on an analysis of the concept of mechanism.<sup>14</sup>

5. A thought of such depth and interest one could not imagine Kant letting fall again, once he had conceived it. It accordingly runs, under various forms, through his later philosophy, although the altered point of view gives it a different position and form. — In the same year in which the «Beweisgrund» came into being, there occurred (as will be shown later) an important change in Kant's interest. This turned from the objective problems to an investigation of the method for treating them. It was along this path that Kant approached the turning point mentioned earlier, in which the critical philosophy came into being in principle. In the very work in which this principle was pronounced (*Dissertatio de mundi sensibilis et intelligibilis forma atque principiis*, 1770) we meet again (in ch. 4) the train of thought familiar from the older writings. Besides the connection among the things in the world, which appears in the forms of time and space, there is postulated an objective principle for the real interaction by which a world-whole becomes possible. The question runs: «How is it possible that substances can stand in a

---

<sup>14</sup>*Drei Bücher der Metaphysik*. Leipzig 1879. p. 135 ff. (Already in *Mikrokosmos*. Third Book, ch. 5.) In the most recent times Fr. *Paulsen* has aligned himself with this way of regarding the matter (*Einleitung in die Philosophie*. Berlin 1892. p. 212–224).

relation of interaction to one another and thereby belong to one and the same whole, which we call world?» (§ 16). And the answer is that this is possible only when they all have one source and thus are not substances in the absolute sense.<sup>15</sup>

When Kant sent the Dissertation to Lambert, he remarked (letter to Lambert of 2 September 1770) that the chapter in which this train of thought is found could be passed over as inessential (*unerheblich*). The fact was that an entirely different problem had now pushed itself into the foreground, in that Kant had come to the conviction that space and time are merely subjective forms of intuition, so that things, insofar as we apprehend them in space and time, are known only as phenomena. He still supposed, to be sure, that by means of the concept of cause and other concepts of the understanding we could know things in themselves (noumena). But immediately after the appearance of the Dissertation he nevertheless felt great difficulties with this assumption. By pursuing them he then came (as we shall later show somewhat more closely) to the result that *all* our scientific knowledge concerns only phenomena, not things in themselves.

It is clear that he could now no longer, in the same way as before, infer from the mechanism of nature to an objective unitary ground. The principle of the firm connection in the world of phenomena became a purely subjective principle, the connecting power of consciousness. The point of unity of the world-view now lay no longer in a mystical primal ground, but in the knowing subject itself. Thus it is said in a note that seems to date from the 1770s (the interval between the Dissertation and the «Kritik der reinen Vernunft»): «The exposition of what is given rests (when one regards the material as undetermined) on the ground of all relation and of the linking-together of representations (or sensations). The linking-together is grounded ... not on the mere phenomenon, but is a representation of that *inner act of consciousness*: to *connect representations*, not merely to place them side by side for intuition, but to make a whole out of them as regards content ... The exposition of phenomena is thus the determination of the ground on which the connection of sensations in them rests.»<sup>16</sup>

With this thought the critical philosophy was completed. It rests on the fundamental thought that our entire conception of the world bears the stamp of the mode of operation of our mind. The laws of our reason hold for all possible phenomena, because these are known to us only in that our reason intuitively and thinks them in its own way and according to its own laws. But the continuity in Kant's thinking shows itself here, for also for the critical philosophy the causal connection (besides the connection in space

---

<sup>15</sup> *Totum e substantiis necessariis est impossibile* (§ 18). — *Unitas in conjunctione substantiarum universi est consecretarium dependentiæ omnium ab Uno* (§ 20).

<sup>16</sup> *Lose Blätter aus Kants Nachlass*. Communicated by Rudolf Reicke. First fascicle. Königsberg 1889 p. 16.

and time) is the basic fact from which the inference to the principle of unity is drawn — only that the principle of unity, as said, is now subjective, not objective. The fundamental concept of the «Kritik der reinen Vernunft», synthesis as the expression of cognitive activity at all its levels, is the subjective counterpart of the objective unitary ground to which Kant in his youthful works sought back. From seeking the ground that holds the *world* together and makes it an objective whole, he has now passed over to seeking the ground that holds the *world-picture* together and makes it a subjective whole. In its innermost essence, as connecting unitary activity, as synthesis, the knowing mind is then a prototype of everything that is to be capable of being known, since this must always have a character of unity. As Kant says: «Ich bin das Original aller Objecte» [I am the original of all objects], or: «Das Gemüth [i.e. consciousness] ist sich selbst das Urbild der Synthesis» [The mind is to itself the archetype of synthesis].<sup>17</sup> — No longer *substance*, but *synthesis*, is the fundamental concept. Thereby is designated the critical philosophy's opposition to the dogmatic.

6. In the «Kritik der reinen Vernunft» there is, as regards the critique of the so-called proofs of God's existence, nothing essentially new in relation to the pre-critical writings. What is new here is something negative: the omission of the train of thought which in its time (still in the Dissertation) had, for Kant, formed a bridge between scientific knowledge and religious faith. This bridge fell away when the application of the concepts of the understanding was restricted to the world of experience. Only by a leap is it now possible to pass from the conditioned world of experience to the unconditioned that religious faith seeks, and this leap occurs by virtue of practical, moral motives, not of a craving for knowledge. Experience, which is always conditioned, cannot ground the thought of an unconditioned cause.<sup>18</sup> Herewith the inference from the causal connection in the world to an absolute unitary ground has fallen away.<sup>19</sup>

But the great interest in causal knowledge and the consistent carrying-through of it in its strictly scientific form does not fall away with the restriction of its applicability to the world of phenomena. It is recovered in the manner in which Kant traces all the

---

<sup>17</sup> *Lose Blätter* I. p. 19. 20.

<sup>18</sup> *Kritik der reinen Vernunft* 2nd ed. p. 665. — The train of thought by which Kant in his time (see § 4) had attempted to recast the ontological proof he has now also given up as demonstrative. But the idea of the absolute being as the ground of all possibilities has not thereby fallen away. It appears as «the transcendental ideal», the highest measure of everything to which reality is ascribed. See *Kritik der reinen Vernunft*. 2nd ed. p. 600; 606. Already in the «Dissertation» the highest theoretical idea is *exemplar aliqvod, omnium aliorum, qvoad realitates, mensura communis* (§ 9). Here, then, a metamorphosis analogous to the subjectivising of the «unitary ground» has taken place.

<sup>19</sup> The problem of interaction is, however, mentioned in *Prolegomena* p. 98 f. and *Kritik der reinen Vernunft*. 2nd ed. p. 265 note, 292 f., 428, and in a manner that shows that Kant has not forgotten his old thought. Cf. also *Reflexionen Kants*. II. p. 219 f. *Lose Blätter* I. p. 274.

various principles that contain the conditions for a possible experience back to the *law of continuity*. The four classes of principles which in Kant's system correspond to the four classes of categories (just as these in turn correspond to the four classes of logical judgments) are summed up in four mottoes: 1) *In Mundo non datur hiatus*. 2) *In Mundo non datur saltus*. 3) *In Mundo non datur casus*. 4) *In Mundo non datur fatum*. And as a common characteristic of them all it holds that they exclude whatever would interrupt the continuous connection.<sup>20</sup> Kant has, in this remarkable passage, gathered his entire theory of knowledge into the law of continuity. Had he laid this point of view at the foundation instead of following the logical systematics he had to his delight managed to construct, his fundamental thoughts would have come more into their own. There are traces that he thought of taking this path, in that in a note from the 1770s he tries to derive the causal law from the general law of continuity: «That everything contingent, or whatever comes into being, must have its ground, comes from the fact that without a *prius* there would be no continuity in the phenomena, and without a rule no identity.»<sup>21</sup>

The thought that here lies at the foundation is that what we seek in the understanding of a phenomenon is not a mere external juxtaposition of it with other phenomena, but such a close and definite connection among them that the phenomenon we seek to understand can stand as a continuation of the preceding phenomena and together with them form a continuous series. The incoherent and isolated is unintelligible to us. This important consideration Kant has only hinted at; but it lies as a germ in the conception and application of the concept of cause for which he spoke up from his youth onward. The most acute of his nearest successors has clearly expressed this thought.<sup>22</sup>

The unbroken connection of nature Kant energetically maintains for the phenomenal world. In the interesting section «Die Disciplin der reinen Vernunft in Ansehung der Hypothesen» he demands that no grounds of explanation be employed which do not, according to known laws, hang together with the given phenomena. It is the principle of *vera causa*, which he himself had applied in so grand a manner in his cosmogonic hypothesis. It retains its place in his methodology. And he demands that it be applied particularly where the greatest temptation to violate it has shown itself, namely in the explanation of order and purposiveness in nature. «Nature's order and purposiveness», he says, «must always be explained by natural grounds and according to natural laws,

---

<sup>20</sup> *Kritik der reinen Vernunft*, 2nd ed. p. 282.

<sup>21</sup> *Reflexionen Kants*. I. p. 308 (No. 1074). Cf. p. 514 (Nos. 1747–50).

<sup>22</sup> *Salomon Maimon: Versuch über die Transscendentalphilosophie*. Berlin 1790. p. 140: «Die Ursache der Erscheinung [aufzusuchen, heisst] *das Stetige* in derselben aufzusuchen, und *die Lücken unserer Wahrnehmungen auszufüllen*, um sie dadurch zu Erfahrungen zu machen. Denn was versteht man sonst in der Naturlehre unter dem Wort Ursache als die Entwicklung einer Erscheinung und Auflösung derselben, so dass man zwischen ihr und der vorhergehenden Erscheinung die gesuchte Stetigkeit finde.»

and here even the wildest hypotheses, provided only they are natural, are more tolerable than supernatural ones, that is, than the appeal to a supernatural author, which one assumes for this need.»<sup>23</sup>

7. Still more decidedly does Kant, in his last work in the field of theoretical philosophy, return to the great thought of his youth. The «*Kritik der Urtheilskraft*» [Critique of the Power of Judgment] (1790) sets itself in a way the same task as «*Allgemeine Naturgeschichte*» and «*Beweisgrund*», namely the investigation of how beauty and purposiveness in the world are to be explained. Kant comes, after many critical reservations, to the result that the difference we make, in our way of regarding nature, between the mechanical and the teleological conception does not justify the assumption that an analogous duality of principles exists in the essence of things. He seeks to show that when, in the case of certain natural phenomena, we are led on account of their special peculiarity to assume a purpose as explanatory ground, while in the case of simpler phenomena we do not feel this need — this has its ground in the nature of our understanding, and we may not ascribe absolute significance to it. The so-called teleological problem is for Kant only one form of the general problem that all our experience sets us: how the manifold can be connected into unity through common laws — the problem that has followed Kant through his entire philosophical development. And although he — at least as regards mode of expression — makes as great concessions as possible to natural theology, he nevertheless points, as his real result, to the possibility that «the physico-mechanical and the teleological connection in the ground of nature unknown to us may hang together in one principle, only that our reason is not in a position to unite them in such a principle.»<sup>24</sup> The thought, familiar from the youthful writings, of a common foundation for the ultimate possibilities of things and for the divine wisdom here shows itself by no means to have been given up, although it comes forward with still greater caution and hedged about with critical correctives. Kant has described an arc from his first nature-philosophical essays, through the critical purgatory, to the profound intimations with which his work of thought ends. Despite the altered points of view, a continuity in the conception of the world nevertheless preserves itself, which it is here of peculiar interest to note.

---

<sup>23</sup>*Kritik der reinen Vernunft*. 2nd ed. p. 800 f.

<sup>24</sup>*Kritik der Urtheilskraft*. § 70 (cf. § 76, 80, 88).

## II.

### Analysis and Construction

8. We now return to an earlier point in Kant's development in order to pursue another train of thought in him, just as we have sought to follow the concept of cause. That the various trains of thought intersect one another in the course of the development goes without saying; but it may nevertheless have its advantage to disentangle them each by itself. The continuity thereby emerges more clearly. And on the most important points we shall not fail to investigate their interaction.

The year 1762 (and the beginning of the following year) is one of the most fruitful in Kant's literary life. No fewer than four significant treatises date from this year, which already by this strong production draws attention to itself. One of these works we already know: «Einzig möglicher Beweisgrund». It treated the concept of cause in its significance for natural science and as a connecting link between the knowledge of nature and the knowledge of God. It contained, as a particular example, a brief survey of the cosmogonic hypothesis set up seven years earlier. The other three writings («Die falsche Spitzfindigkeit der syllogistischen Figuren» [The False Subtlety of the Four Syllogistic Figures]; «Ueber die Deutlichkeit der Grundsätze der natürlichen Theologie und Moral» [On the Distinctness of the Principles of Natural Theology and Morality]; «Versuch den Begriff der negativen Grössen in die Weltweisheit einzuführen» [Attempt to Introduce the Concept of Negative Magnitudes into Philosophy])<sup>25</sup> discuss seemingly quite different questions. And yet the investigations carried out in them became of great importance precisely for the conception of the very concept on whose significance for natural science and natural theology Kant had, even in the «Beweisgrund», laid such great weight. In the year mentioned (whose productivity is perhaps explained precisely thereby) two trains of thought had moved in Kant's consciousness, whose collision was bound to confront him with an important problem.

In his critique of the syllogistic figures Kant proceeds from the point of view that every judgment is a comparison. To judge is to compare a mark with a thing and, as a result of this comparison, either to ascribe the thing to it or to deny it of the thing.<sup>26</sup>

---

<sup>25</sup>The four writings seem (cf. B. Erdmann: *Reflexionen Kants*. I. p. XVII ff.) to have appeared in the following order: 1) Spitzfindigkeit; 2) Beweisgrund; 3) Deutlichkeit; 4) Negative Grössen. — For the relation among their content of thought the order of composition and publication is of course not decisive.

<sup>26</sup>«Etwas als ein Merkmal mit einem Dinge vergleichen heisst urtheilen» (*Ueber die falsche Spitzfindigkeit*. § 1). — Cf. «Träume eines Geistersehers» [Dreams of a Spirit-Seer] (1766): «Unsere Vernunftregel gehet nur auf die Vergleichung nach der Identität und dem Widerspruche». (2. Th. 3. Hauptst.) (Kehrbach's edition, p. 64.)

A similar conception of the nature of thinking lies at the foundation of the treatise «on the distinctness of the principles». Here the difference between the philosophical and the mathematical method is impressed upon us. Philosophy's method is analysis, mathematics' construction. Mathematics can at once form finished concepts with which one can operate. But in philosophy, which draws its material from experience, the determination of the concept becomes finished only when the analysis of the given is completed. Here, then, is the difficulty: how can one convince oneself that the analysis has been carried far enough, so that there are no more marks to discover? In mathematics, therefore, definitions form the beginning, whereas in philosophy they can come only at the end. The imperfections of earlier philosophy are derived from the fact that one has operated with unfinished concepts and embarked on premature constructions. As an example of a concept with which, in dogmatic philosophy, one has confidently operated as though it were finished and complete, is mentioned the concept of spirit (thinking substance), which played so great a role in Descartes, Leibniz, and Wolff. It was arbitrarily constructed, not grounded on a carried-through analysis.<sup>27</sup> To carry through the analysis of complex cognitions Kant declares far more difficult than to combine simple cognitions by synthesis and build inferences upon them. Metaphysics is therefore the most difficult of all sciences — but then no metaphysics has yet been written either! It will still be a very long time before one can proceed synthetically in metaphysics. This can happen only when analysis has helped toward clear and fully developed concepts.

A consequence might here lie near at hand: only such relations are intelligible in which thinking can, along the path of analysis, lead from the one term of the relation over to the other. This consequence Kant did not, however, draw in the treatise «on distinctness». By contrast, the fourth writing, the treatise on negative magnitudes in philosophy, acquires its great interest from the fact that this consequence is drawn with full clarity. In that Kant in this writing impresses the distinction — so often overlooked by speculative philosophers of all ages — between logical negation and real opposition, he naturally also comes to investigate such cases where something is annulled because something else enters in; and here he stands before the causal problem. Along the path of analysis or comparison one cannot show the necessity of the connection between the

---

<sup>27</sup>«Träume eines Geistersehers» is really only a closer development of this example, in order to show what it leads to, to operate with unfinished concepts. The concept of spirit (in the spiritualist sense) is here declared a *surreptitious* concept. The result of the ingenious work is: «Die Pneumatologie der Menschen kann ein Lehrbegriff ihrer nothwendigen Unwissenheit in Absicht auf eine vermuthete Art Wesen genannt werden» (1. Th. 4. Hauptst.). (Kehrbach's edition, p. 43.) Cf. herewith Kant's «Nachricht von der Einrichtung seiner Vorlesungen» (1765–66), where it is said that empirical psychology does not at all ask whether man has a soul. — As one sees, not only the critique of theology, but also the critique of rational [i.e. spiritualist] psychology was essentially finished at this point of Kant's development.

entering of the one and the ceasing of the other, any more than one can show in general that something happens because something else happens. Kant lets the problem stand unsolved. Only this much is he certain of, that the principle of contradiction, to which dogmatism would trace back all grounding, gives no explanation.<sup>28</sup>

Kant has here posed the causal problem, in part in terms similar to those in which *Hume* had already posed it. But Kant had really already had to do with the causal problem in his earlier writings, most recently in the «Beweisgrund». What lay at the foundation of the train of thought which for him connected the knowledge of nature and the knowledge of God, and on which he believed himself first to have entered (see § 3), was the impossibility of understanding the interaction, the causal connection among the things in the world, when one did not assume a common ground for them. So long as they stand in their diversity, the causal relation among them is unintelligible. What has happened in the remarkable concluding statements in the treatise on negative magnitudes is therefore really not the setting up of an entirely new problem, but *the transposition of a problem, hitherto treated in metaphysical-objective form, into epistemological-subjective form*. It is understandable that Kant, now that he had reworked anew the views he had first presented seven years before, and as he at the same time came upon purely logical and methodological investigations, was bound, through the collision of these two trains of thought, to come to see that the causal relation poses not only an objective but also a subjective problem. Of this year's so intense and productive work of thought, this transposition is the most important fruit — to be sure a fruit that could not yet come to full maturity. The concept which he himself had applied in such an ingenious way in his inquiry into nature, and which only recently had built a bridge for him between the regions of religion and natural science, now suddenly showed itself to contain so great a problem when one raised the simple question of how one passes from the one term of the relation it indicates to the other.

That there was such a connection for Kant between the causal problem in its metaphysical and in its epistemological form is clearly seen from the statement in «Träume eines Geistersehers» (in the concluding chapter). Here attention is once more drawn to the causal problem, and that in connection with the general problem of the nature of spiritual beings and their relation to matter. It is shown how the problems begin within

---

<sup>28</sup> *Versuch den Begriff der negativen Grössen in die Weltweisheit einzuführen*. (The statements on the causal problem are found in the concluding remark.) — Cf. «Träume» (2. Th. 3. Hauptst.): «Unsere Vernunftregel gehet nur auf die Vergleichung nach der Identität und dem Widerspruche. So ferne aber etwas eine Ursache ist, so wird dadurch etwas gesetzt, und es ist also kein Zusammenhang vermöge der Einstimmung anzutreffen; wie denn auch, wenn ich eben dasselbe nicht als eine Ursache ansehen will, niemals ein Widerspruch entspringt». (Kehrbach's edition, p. 64.)

speculation, where one confidently operates with the «fundamental relations» (cause and effect, substance and action), but that one, when one continues to philosophise, ends by finding difficulties in the fundamental relations themselves. And this connection between the metaphysical and the epistemological problem emerges still more clearly in the letter to Mendelssohn of 8 April 1766, in that here the general question of how something can be a cause unfolds out of the more special one of how a spiritual substance can have the power to act and to be acted upon in relation to matter.

I find, in accordance with the foregoing, the continuity in Kant's development at a different point than *Friedrich Paulsen*. This scholar lays the weight on the fact that Kant, on closer investigation of the metaphysical concept of God — according to which God was to be the sum-total of all realities — discovered that there are indeed realities which stand in a relation of real opposition to one another and thus do not admit of being united. The treatise on negative magnitudes would then be a special investigation, called forth by the theological considerations in the «Beweisgrund».<sup>29</sup> That there is a connection between the «Beweisgrund» and the treatise on negative magnitudes I do not deny. Already in the «Beweisgrund» there is maintained, as Paulsen has shown, the important difference between logical negation and real opposition. But the main thing for me is the peculiar and sudden turn that Kant makes in the concluding remark to the last-named writing. He could have discussed the problem of negative magnitudes at length and thoroughly without precisely drawing the consequence he there draws. It is this turn that I can explain to myself only by the fact that the causal relation was precisely present to Kant as the most important thing in all knowledge. It was bound, then, to come to a collision.

9. Kant's whole mood at the close of the year so rich in work of thought was decidedly anti-dogmatic. From confidently operating with hitherto recognised concepts he had now been led to investigate some of the most important of these concepts and had found them obscure and unfinished. He now felt great difficulties with what others — and he himself hitherto — found easy. With irony he turns against «the thorough philosophers, whose number is constantly increasing», with a request to solve for him these simple questions at which he had come to a halt. Still more strongly and more boldly did this mood come forth in «Träume eines Geistersehers», which mocks the «builders of air-castles» who construct their edifices out of surreptitious concepts, and toward whom there is nothing else to do but to wait until they have finished dreaming.

The strong opposition between construction and analysis itself denotes a break with

---

<sup>29</sup>*Entwicklungsgeschichte der Kantischen Erkenntnisstheorie*. p. 64 ff.

the philosophy of the preceding age. Kant demands that an entirely new foundation be procured before the time for philosophical systematisation could come. His attention was from now on directed toward method, toward the investigation of the limits of knowledge. He had surely already at this time<sup>30</sup> struck out upon the antinomic method for demonstrating the limit of knowledge, in that he found such a limit where, concerning the same problem, self-contradictory propositions could be grounded. «I attempted», he says later,<sup>31</sup> «in full earnest to prove propositions and the opposite of them, not in order to maintain scepticism, but because I suspected that an illusion of the understanding was present, and in order to discover wherein it consisted». In a letter to Lambert (of 31 December 1765) he says that his efforts are chiefly directed toward the peculiar method of metaphysics. He has now, after several years' deliberation, found a method which he employs in order to avoid imagined knowledge. In every investigation he looks to see what he must know in order to be able to solve the problem, and what degree of knowledge the given permits; his judgment thereby becomes, to be sure, often more limited, but also more certain than is usually the case. In agreement with this he states in «Träume» that metaphysics is the doctrine of the limits of knowledge, and in «Nachricht von der Einrichtung seiner Vorlesungen» that a «Critik der Vernunft» is a chief task for him in his treatment of logic. To about the same time surely belongs also a fragment in which it is said: «Die Metaphysik ist die Kritik der menschlichen Vernunft ... [sie] ist subjectiv und problematisch».<sup>32</sup>

10. Those Kant scholars are surely right who have sought to show that the development that takes place in Kant's thinking in 1762 and the following years does not *necessarily* presuppose an influence from without, but *in itself* can very well be understood from his preceding development. But on the other hand I know no period in Kant's development to which the expression «awakening from dogmatic slumber» would fit so well as here. Even *Benno Erdmann*, who places the awakening far later (so much later that it seems to me he comes into conflict with Kant's statement that the awakening took place «vor vielen Jahren» [many years ago]), declares the time in the 1760s to be the period in which «the Kantian thoughts were most in flux». To be awakened from dogmatic slumber means precisely that flux comes into the hitherto fixed thoughts. To be sure, if by the expression «awakening from dogmatic slumber» one will understand

---

<sup>30</sup>As *Benno Erdmann* has shown in the introduction to his edition of *Prolegomena*, p. LXXVI f. and more fully in *Reflexionen Kants*. II. p. XXXV–XLVII.

<sup>31</sup>*Reflexionen Kants*. II. p. 4 (No. 4). With this agrees a statement in the letter to Garve of 21 September 1798, that it was the cosmological antinomies of pure reason that «first awakened him from his dogmatic slumber and drove him to the critique of reason in order to remove the scandal of reason's apparent contradiction with itself». (The letter is printed in *Alb. Stern: Ueber die Beziehungen Garve's zu Kant*.)

<sup>32</sup>*Reflexionen Kants*. II. p. 158 (No. 507).

the complete transition to the critical philosophy, then it does not fit this moment. In this strict sense B. Erdmann takes it, when he first finds it applicable where the hope of an intellectual knowledge of things in themselves «was not merely eradicated to the last fibre, but was even replaced by a contrarily opposed conception».<sup>33</sup> This is surely to demand too much of an awakening. Kant himself has, in a draft of a preface to the «*Kritik der reinen Vernunft*», stated: «It was long before I found the whole dogmatic theory dialectical. But I sought for something certain, if not with respect to the object, then at least with respect to the nature and limits of knowledge.»<sup>34</sup> He who seeks thus is awake. We have also heard that he himself at this time regarded the dogmatists as dreaming. I cannot see otherwise than that the sharp opposition between construction and analysis, the great weight on method and on the limits of knowledge, as well as the low opinion of what had hitherto been achieved in philosophy, decidedly place Kant outside the circle of the dogmatists already at this time. Only from a (in the Kantian sense) «hypercritical» standpoint could he in this period be called resting in dogmatic slumber. Should Kant nevertheless in the year 1783 have reckoned the period of the 1760s to dogmatism, then he has done himself a great injustice. His own definition of the concept of dogmatism was, after all, that it consisted in «the presumption of getting through merely with a pure knowledge of concepts, according to such principles as reason has long had in use, *without investigating the manner in which, and the right by which, it has arrived at them*»,<sup>35</sup> or, as it is said in another place: «the general confidence in the principles of metaphysics *without a preceding critique of the faculty of reason itself*».<sup>36</sup> According to this definition Kant could not, in the period from 1762, be called a dogmatist. He had, to be sure, not — not even in «*Träume eines Geistersehers*» — given up the hope that diligent work along the path of analysis might one day make a constructive knowledge possible. But he had a clear eye for the difficulties and very little confidence in the current principles, as well as a definite conviction that the result, if any came, would be bound up with a limitation of our knowledge. If he himself later reckoned this period to the period of dogmatic slumber, then the results of the «*Critique*» must have blinded his view of his own past. — The question of the moment of the awakening it is nevertheless not possible to decide with certainty according to what is available. I can only not see otherwise than that the placing of it in the year 1762–63<sup>37</sup> is most probable, though such

---

<sup>33</sup>*Einleitung zu Prolegomena*, p. XCII.

<sup>34</sup>*Reflexionen Kants*. II. p. 4 (No. 3). — I lay the emphasis on the word «whole».

<sup>35</sup>*Kritik der reinen Vernunft*. 2nd ed. Preface, p. XXXV.

<sup>36</sup>*Ueber eine Entdeckung, nach der alle neue Kritik der reinen Vernunft durch eine ältere entbehrlich gemacht werden soll*. Königsberg 1790. p. 78.

<sup>37</sup>To this moment the «awakening» is assigned by *Kuno Fischer*, *Riehl*, and *Vaihinger* (the last of whom, however, also assumes a later awakening). My grounds are, however, different from those of these scholars.

eminent Kant scholars as Fr. *Paulsen* and *Benno Erdmann* have come to other results. As repeatedly remarked, the uncertainty about this question is a testimony to the continuity in Kant's development.

11. *Benno Erdmann*<sup>38</sup> believes, from Herder's utterances from the years in which he was Kant's auditor (1762–64), that one can infer that Kant cannot at that time have been awakened by Hume. One would otherwise, Erdmann holds, have noticed something, in the manner in which Herder speaks of Hume, of the enthusiasm which Kant must undoubtedly have instilled in his auditors for the English thinker.

This assumption does not seem to me compelling, especially when one holds fast that the awakening must have had a highly indirect character, so that it essentially consisted in a release and full clarification of thoughts and doubts that had already begun to work their way forward. It was, by Kant's statement, «the recollection of Hume» that awakened him. So Kant had earlier read Hume (it is the latter's «Inquiry» in German translation that is in question here), but the thought of Hume's posing of the problem influenced him only later. It is easily understandable that this recollection of a reading which in its time had made no stronger impression could come forth in Kant precisely in the year when the two trains of thought that had hitherto run side by side in his consciousness — the causal relation as expression of the connection of various elements, and thinking as analysis, operating with the principle of contradiction alone — were both taken up for new, penetrating treatment and easily had to come into collision. One may suppose that «the recollection of Hume» either favoured this collision or strengthened its effects. But Kant can in any case scarcely have been able right away to have full consciousness of the significance of what was going on in him; a such consciousness could come only when the process of development that was initiated by the awakening lay quite finished before the retrospective gaze. Thereby it is also understood that he does not mention the awakening by Hume in his writings until long afterward and, as Erdmann himself has shown, on a special occasion.

There is no reason to assume that Kant, in his lectures at the time Herder heard him, should have spoken of Hume (as theoretical philosopher) otherwise than he constantly spoke of him later, namely as the sceptic who forms a sound counterweight and a beneficial ferment over against dogmatism. Kant moreover still lacked the «higher unity», criticism, which he later used to let triumph over dogmatism and scepticism, and he had then to regard Hume predominantly as an opponent to be overcome. In the utterances that Erdmann cites from Herder, the latter speaks of Hume precisely in

---

<sup>38</sup>«Kant und Hume um 1762». *Archiv für die Geschichte der Philosophie*. I. p. 62–77; 216–230.

the manner we should expect, namely as a fine mind, but at the same time as an arch-doubter; he even accuses him of «ein *erstrebtes* Zweifeln» [a contrived doubting]. I do not understand how Erdmann, after these utterances, can infer<sup>39</sup> that Kant — when one relies on Herder's testimony — in these years did not appreciate in Hume the metaphysical doubter, but only the moralist. The doubter in Hume Herder does after all seem to have been made sufficiently aware of! Herder has surely even exaggerated the matter. The expression «erstrebt» must probably stand to his account, not to Kant's.<sup>40</sup> It was, given Herder's whole natural disposition and intellectual direction, not strange that Hume's doubt could seem to him exaggerated and arbitrary. Herder had not the use for it that Kant had, who got his thoughts more strongly set in motion by it; indeed, Herder could perhaps not even understand what use Kant could have for it; his later relation to Kant gives ground to suppose so. What Herder appreciated to so high a degree in Kant at this time was (according to the well-known statement in the «Letters on Humanity») the open sense for everything human, as well as for nature, the lively mind and the clear understanding. For the seeking thinker, wandering along solitary and thorny paths, Herder had no sense.

12. By the clear distinction between construction and analysis Kant had made a great advance. The fault of the dogmatic systems was that they proceeded too quickly to construction, even though they naturally could not entirely dispense with analysis, which — however incomplete and unfinished — in reality always forms the preparation. Kant saw for the present, in the more exact analysis, the most important means of progress. And — what is of particular interest for holding fast the continuity in his development — he really never gave up, not even in the «Kritik der reinen Vernunft», the relation between analysis and construction that he had presented in the writing «on the distinctness of the principles».

By his emphasis on the significance of analysis Kant meets with *Lambert's* efforts. But while Kant sees construction lying in the indeterminate distance and holds that for the present it is the time of analysis, Lambert assumes that the goal lies nearer.

---

<sup>39</sup> *Archiv*. I. p. 216.

<sup>40</sup> A letter from Kant to Herder of 9 May 1767 (of which I became aware only through a kind gift from the librarian Dr. R. Reicke in Königsberg) shows that Kant nevertheless at this time had a more positive conception of Hume than one would suppose from Herder's utterances. Kant wishes his young friend that he may attain that (by no means unfeeling) calm in its stead, which is peculiar to the philosopher as opposed to the mystic, and adds thereto: «Ich hoffe diese Epoche Ihres Genies aus demjenigen was ich von Ihnen kenne mit Zuversicht, eine Gemüthsverfassung, die dem so sie besitzt und der Welt unter allen am nützlichsten ist, worin Montaigne den untersten und *Hume so viel ich weiss den obersten Platz einnehmen*». This, in Kant's mouth, great praise must, according to the whole context, apply not merely to «the moralist». (The letter is printed in *Altpreuss. Monatsschrift*. Bd. 28. Heft 3 u. 4. 1891: *Zu Herders Briefwechsel. Von Victor Diederichs*.)

By comparison and combination of the simple concepts to which analysis has led, he will without further ado form axioms and postulates (letter to Kant, November 1765). He sees well that a closer testing of the various combinations is necessary;<sup>41</sup> but he feels no need to find special principles according to which this testing of the possible principles could take place. He approaches it in the remarkable statement (letter to Kant, February 1766) in which he raises the question whether the knowledge of the form of our knowledge leads to knowledge of the content of our knowledge. But the fundamental difficulty in the transition from analysis of the fundamental concepts to construction of the principles he has not come to a halt at, nor did he carry analysis in the definite direction by which Kant was led to find the sole possibility of constructive knowledge in philosophy. Although Kant therefore honoured Lambert as his predecessor so highly that he would have dedicated the «Kritik der reinen Vernunft» to him had he not died before the work's completion,<sup>42</sup> it was nevertheless his judgment of him that he moved within mere analysis, without reaching the «critical» standpoint.<sup>43</sup>

The analysis that plays so great a role in Kant's definitive theory of knowledge concerns the manner in which the faculty of knowledge itself operates. This direction Kant's analysis already took when a more careful determination of the limits of knowledge proved necessary (see § 9). But it led to decisive results only when, from 1769 onward, he began to distinguish between the material and the form of knowledge. How this turning point came about will be discussed later; here it shall only be investigated of what kind the analysis was by which Kant grounded this distinction so important for his definitive system.

Kant has nowhere methodically carried out this analysis. He constantly presupposes it or hints at it in great brevity. In the «Dissertation» it is said that by attending to the manner in which consciousness operates on the occasion of experience (*attendendo ad ejus actiones occasione experientiae*) we discover the laws according to which this operation goes on. Now when, in sensible knowledge, a distinction is made between material and form, such that form means the law for consciousness's ordering of the received material, then it emerges from the expressions Kant uses that form is the constant, unchangeable element in sensation, whereas the material is that which varies infinitely. Analysis thus finds a difference between a constant and a changing, a determinate and an indeterminate.<sup>44</sup> The form stands as an unchangeable prototype (*typus immutabilis*),

---

<sup>41</sup>J. H. Lambert: *Neues Organon*. Leipzig 1764. I, p. 323 f.; 499.

<sup>42</sup>See the draft of a dedication: *Reflexionen Kants*. II. p. 1 f.

<sup>43</sup>*Reflexionen Kants*. II. p. 67 f. (Nos. 225, 227, 231).

<sup>44</sup>*Tempus est ... subjectiva conditio per naturam mentis humanæ necessaria, quælibet sensibilia certa lege sibi coordinandi* (Diss. § 14, 5). — *Spatium est ... subjectivum et ideale e natura mentis stabili lege*

which is constantly imitated anew, every time a new content is to be ordered. In notes from the 1770s the same trait is found. «The exposition of what is thought rests merely on consciousness; but the exposition of what is given rests — *when one regards the material as indeterminate* — on the ground of all relation and connection among the representations». And when we make clear to ourselves according to what laws this connection goes on, we obtain «an original of all objects», «an archetype for every possible synthesis», which can be known apart from, or «independently of the particular composition in which it was given» (*unabhängig von der Einzelheit darin es gegeben war*).<sup>45</sup>

Also in the «Kritik der reinen Vernunft» there are traces of the analysis by which form is separated from material. When Kant — by an unfortunate mode of expression — says that we can know the form *prior to actual observation*, he presupposes that such an analysis has already been carried out, and by actual observation he means: any *definite, particular* observation. — A few examples will show this.

«*When I separate off from the representation of a body what the understanding thinks about it (substance, force, divisibility, etc.), and likewise that part of it which belongs to sensation (impenetrability, hardness, colour, etc.), then I still have something left over from this empirical intuition, namely extension and figure. These belong to the pure intuition that takes place in consciousness even without any actual object of sensation or feeling, as the mere form of sensibility*». There is described here an analysis, that is, a successive directing of attention to the various sides or elements of the given, and the results of the analysis are divided into three different classes, which are referred to the three faculties, understanding, form of intuition, and sensation.<sup>46</sup> How the «separating-off» is more closely grounded is seen from other places. «Space and time are [sensibility's] pure forms, sensation *in general* is the material. ... The former hang together *entirely necessarily* with our sensibility, *of whatever kind our sensations may be*; the latter may be *very different*». «We call the synthesis of the manifold in the imagination transcendental when, *apart from any difference in what is intuited (ohne Unterschied der Anschauungen)*, it bears on nothing but the connection of the manifold a priori». «Apperception, and with it thinking, precedes *all possible definite arrangement of the representations*».<sup>47</sup> — And in a place in «Prolegomena», where Kant reports on the genesis of the doctrine of

---

*proficiscens, veluti schema, omnia omnino externe sensa sibi coordinandi.* (Diss. § 15 D).

<sup>45</sup>Lose Blätter. I. p. 16; 19–21. (Cf. above § 5, conclusion).

<sup>46</sup>Kant expresses himself here in the manner of the old theory of abstraction, although in other places he definitely rejects this. See «Kritik der reinen Vernunft». 2nd ed. p. 457 (the note to the first Antithesis). *Reflexionen Kants*. II. p. 126 (No. 412).

<sup>47</sup>*Kritik der reinen Vernunft*. 2nd ed. p. 35; 60; 118; 345.

the categories, he says: «I looked about for an act of understanding that contained every other and offered differences only through the *various modifications or moments* under which the manifold of representation is brought under the unity of thinking. Then I found that this act of understanding consisted in judging.»<sup>48</sup>

There arose at the same time the task for Kant of finding common marks for the constant elements which he could thus gradually single out in our knowledge. This part of the analysis went hand in hand with the demonstration of the constant elements, in that Kant first became properly aware of these when he had found a common fundamental determination for all our knowledge. This fundamental determination was connection, synthesis, and since it is a function, Kant regarded it as self-evident that it could not be given with the mere impressions. But of this side of the analysis we shall treat more closely in ch. 4. Here we confine ourselves merely to the general significance that the analytic method continued to have for Kant.

This analysis, which aims at finding the very manner in which the faculty of knowledge operates, is expressly distinguished from «the usual procedure in philosophical investigations: to analyse the concepts that present themselves according to their content and bring them to distinctness». The real task of the critical philosophy is an analysis of the faculty of knowledge itself, to find the fundamental concepts there where they spring up, and to demonstrate their application. And this critical analysis, which separates form from material, cannot proceed «until long practice has made us attentive and has put us in a position to single out what our own faculty of knowledge contributes from what we receive through sense impression». Therefore Kant has nothing against granting to the mathematician Kästner that the concept of space is abstracted from sensible representations: «for without application of our sensible mode of representation to actual objects of the senses, even that which a priori is contained in these [i.e. in the senses] would not at all become known to us».<sup>49</sup>

13. The foundation found by analysis for the critical doctrine of knowledge emerges more strongly in the first edition of the «*Kritik der reinen Vernunft*» than in the *Prolegomena* and the second edition.<sup>50</sup> There he develops, in a psychologically very interesting manner, the concept of synthesis as the general form of conscious activity at the various levels. Later he contents himself with referring quite generally to the connecting process, particularly in the domain of the understanding.<sup>51</sup> On account of the misunderstandings

<sup>48</sup>*Prolegomena*. Riga 1783. p. 119.

<sup>49</sup>Dissert. § 15 Coroll. — *Kritik der reinen Vernunft*. 2nd ed. p. 1 f.; 90. — *Wilh. Dilthey: Aus den Rostocker Kanthandschriften. Archiv für die Geschichte der Philosophie*. III. p. 87.

<sup>50</sup>This has been shown by Benno Erdmann: *Einleitung zu Prolegomena*, p. XXXII–XXXVIII.

<sup>51</sup>Cf. also the letter to Tieftrunk of 11 December 1797 on the concept of composition as that which lies

in a psychological-idealist direction of which the «Kritik der reinen Vernunft» at once became the object, Kant in the later reworkings sought to divert attention from the psychological analysis of the cognitive process (from what he in the preface to the first edition called the subjective deduction), which had only a preparatory significance, in order that his chief task — the construction of the rational propositions that hold for all phenomena and yet are independent of them — might emerge all the more sharply.

But the sharp opposition between the method of mathematics and that of philosophy, which Kant had presented in the treatise on the distinctness of the principles, he nevertheless constantly holds fast. In the interesting section «Die Disciplin der reinen Vernunft im dogmatischen Gebrauche» it is expressed in part with the same turns of phrase as in the nearly twenty years older writing. Here too it is shown that the philosophical concepts gained by analysis, not, like the mathematical, by direct construction, cannot in the strictest sense be defined, since there can be no apodictic certainty that the content of the concept is complete. As examples are mentioned the concepts cause, right, and equity. There may be obscure accessory representations present which we do not become aware of in the analysis, and which nevertheless, without our noticing it, play a part in the application.<sup>52</sup>

The difference between the older writings (1762 ff.) and the «Kritik der reinen Vernunft» is that whereas Kant earlier distinguished between two kinds of concepts, empirical and mathematical, of which the former are gained by analysis, the latter by direct construction, he later distinguishes three kinds of concepts: 1) empirical, 2) a-priori-discursive, 3) a-priori-intuitive. The first two kinds are gained by analysis, the last by direct construction. But the analysis by which the first and the second kind are gained is, as has been shown in the foregoing (see above § 12), of different character.

14. For the critique of Kant's theory of knowledge this connection between the older and the later standpoint is of great interest. For it suggests the question whether Kant has really discovered an entirely new class of concepts, which would stand between the empirical and the constructed. In deciding this question one need not go beyond Kant's own statements. For he declares in plain words that the a-priori-discursive concepts (i.e. the categories) are not fully finished — and yet he operates with them to set up principles, as though they were fully finished! If we look to their mode of genesis, then they are subject to the same conditions as the ordinary empirical concepts. They are due, as we

---

at the foundation of all categories.

<sup>52</sup>*Kritik der reinen Vernunft*. 2nd ed. p. 756. — Cf. herewith «Träume eines Geistersehers». 1. Th. 1. Hauptst. (Kehrbach's edition p. 6 note), where the description of surreptitious concepts quite recalls the cited passage of the «Critique».

have seen, to the observation of constant elements amid the variation of our experiences. The assumption that we here have before us the very nature of the faculty of knowledge («the sources», as Kant is wont to say) is an inference from, or an interpretation of, this constancy. It is thus a hypothesis. In the preface to the first edition of the Critique of Reason Kant also says that «the subjective deduction» (i.e. the demonstration of the sources of knowledge by means of analysis) might look like a hypothesis, since it aims at «the demonstration of a cause for a given effect»; but he holds that this is not so, and promises on another occasion to establish it. This promise he has, however, not kept, whereas in his later presentations he has considerably reduced this analytic part.

Kant is thus, in a certain sense, on his definitive standpoint, no further advanced than he was in 1762. He has not shown the possibility of determining the «forms» in such a way that there is full guarantee of the exactness and completeness of the determination. He cannot then really know himself secure against the same charge that he directed against Leibniz and Wolff: of operating with unfinished and surreptitious concepts. And there is a considerable hypothetical element in the system of forms which he sets up as the foundation for our exact experience. He is right that if we could be quite certain that these forms must play a part in all our experience, all our apprehension, then we would also have an a priori knowledge of the objects of experience. But precisely this full certainty cannot be established.<sup>53</sup>

For the theory of knowledge there is here no other path to go than to operate with the foundation found by analysis as with a hypothesis, leaving it to continued analysis to correct the foundation from which one proceeds. The fact is that the various operations stand in a reciprocal relation to one another. But one cannot lay aside all possible construction and set about analysing; that would be to the detriment of analysis itself, since construction may be necessary as an auxiliary process and experiment. Kant's own antinomic method was really attempts at constructions that were to illuminate the character of the presuppositions when these could not be directly analysed. — The reverse also holds, of course, that construction presupposes analysis, for which reason even the mathematical concepts that seem set up by direct construction prove, on closer investigation, to presuppose a preceding analysis. Kant's opposition between mathematics and philosophy is thus not tenable in the form in which he has set it up.

The certainty that in the constant elements of experience we have the necessary forms of our conscious activity can, however far analysis be carried, become only approximate, and the inferences that can be built on this certainty must of course share its fate. Kant's

---

<sup>53</sup>Cf. already *Ænesidemus* [by G. E. Schulze]. 1792 p. 401; 406.

tendency, on his definitive standpoint, to push analysis aside has made him a dogmatist against his will. He saw more correctly in 1762, when he used the analytic method as a weapon against the dogmatists.

15. That analysis has been a stepchild in Kant's definitive philosophy, although it has its definite place in it, shows itself especially in the fact that the derivation of the «forms» from the concrete connection in which, according to Kant, they first display themselves, is not carried through. The relation between the two propositions to which Kant equally subscribes — «All knowledge *begins with* experience», and «Not all knowledge *springs from* experience» — he has not clearly demonstrated. This would only have happened had he presented the various stages of development through which the «forms» pass from the innate foundation to the conscious clarity acquired by practice.<sup>54</sup>

But not only does Kant presuppose the forms as fully finished; he also presupposes them in an ideal perfection and purity in which they do not occur in any actual intuition or experience. That this is so as regards space and time needs no closer demonstration. Newton's absolute space and time are with Kant, so to speak, struck inward, have become subjective forms — without, however, losing their absoluteness. Thus each of the forms of intuition is designated in the Dissertation as *typus immutabilis* (§ 16 Coroll.). Kant thus imagines prototypes, ideal frames, to which everything that appears to us must be referred in order to be worked into a general connection.<sup>55</sup> A similar prototype (*exemplar*) is, according to the Dissertation (§ 9), formed also for intellectual knowledge and provides the common measure for all reality. In the «Kritik der reinen Vernunft» the very concept of experience or of nature arises by a similar ideal construction. The parallel with that «unchangeable prototype» emerges clearly when it is said: «*There is only one experience*, in which all observations are represented in thoroughgoing and law-governed connection, *just as there is only one space and one time*; in the former

---

<sup>54</sup>Cf. the distinction between innateness and original acquisition in Dissert. § 8; Coroll. — *Ueber eine Entdeckung* etc. p. 68. — *Kritik der reinen Vernunft*. 2nd ed. § 27. — Letter to Hertz of 21 February 1772. — From a purely psychological standpoint, too, objection must be raised against Kant's distinction between material and form. Sensations are not merely passively received material, but every sensation is determined in its arising and character by the whole state of consciousness. Here, as far as the sensations themselves are concerned, a forming and connecting, a synthesis, takes place. Cf. my *Psychology*, 3rd ed. p. 130. This objection does not abolish Kant's distinction, but carries it further and in another manner than he did.

<sup>55</sup>As regards time, Kant has not distinguished between sensation of time, representation of time, and intuition of time. Cf. my *Psychology*. 3rd ed. p. 206–214 and my treatise: «*Lotze og den svenske Filosofi*». *Nordisk Tidsskrift*, publ. by the Letterstedt Association 1890. p. 6–10. — As regards space, Kant expresses himself in other writings far more clearly than in the «*Kritik der reinen Vernunft*». Thus it is said in «*Metaphysische Anfangsgründe der Naturwissenschaft*» (Riga 1786). p. 3 f.: «*Der absolute Raum ist an sich nichts und gar kein Object, sondern bedeutet nur einen jeden andern relativen Raum, den ich mir ausser dem gegebenen jederzeit denken kann*». — p. 16: «*Der absolute Raum ist für alle mögliche Erfahrung nichts*».

all phenomena and all relations of being and non-being find their place.»<sup>56</sup> «All our cognitions lie within *all possible totality*». «All phenomena lie in *one nature* and must lie therein, because without the a priori unity there would be no unity of experience and thus no determination of the objects in it possible.»<sup>57</sup> — The last ground that Kant gives for this unity of experience (or of nature) is that conscious knowledge is possible only when the given elements are united by synthesis. Synthetic unity is the principle of all understanding. «If every single representation were quite foreign to, isolated and severed from the others, then there could never arise anything such as knowledge is. For knowledge is a whole of compared and connected representations.»<sup>58</sup> We have therefore, as we have already shown (§ 5 concl.; § 12), in the concept of the synthetic character of our knowing consciousness an archetype for everything we can know.

But to what degree do the actual observations now satisfy the ideal demand that is, on the basis of this prototype, made of them? About this, plainly, nothing can be known beforehand. A prototype formed by abstraction and idealisation of our cognitive activity shows its significance by setting thought in motion. But whether thought finds adequate counterparts of the prototype, and whether it can carry the prototype through amid the unsurveyable manifold of observation, that is the great question, which is not answered by the demonstration that we have necessary knowledge only *if* this happens.

Sometimes Kant also expresses himself, then, as though by the prototype merely a search were initiated. In the Dissertation, accordingly, the principle that everything that happens, happens according to the order of nature, is presented as a subjective principle for our inquiry (*principium convenientiæ*), on a par with the law of parsimony (§ 30). In a note from the 1770s there is talk of a *presumption*, according to which everything can be determined by a rule. In a note «from the first time of criticism» it is asked: «Since we do not see the possibility of a real ground, how can we then a priori see that there absolutely must be such? ... Does this principle not hold as *anticipation*, because without a rule we would have no experiences, and this rule consists in the ordering of time and space according to general laws?» In a note from the 1780s it is said: «The principles for the exposition of phenomena are principles for their intellection, not for their perspicience, *for seeking causes*, not for determining them». And in the «Kritik der reinen Vernunft»: «The understanding is constantly occupied with *scrutinising the phenomena with the aim of finding out a rule for them*». «The understanding can a priori yield no more than to *anticipate the form of a possible experience in general*.»<sup>59</sup>

---

<sup>56</sup> *Kritik der reinen Vernunft*. 1st ed. p. 110.

<sup>57</sup> *Kritik der reinen Vernunft*. 2nd ed. p. 185; 263.

<sup>58</sup> *Kritik der reinen Vernunft*. 1st ed. p. 97 (cf. 2nd ed. p. 103).

<sup>59</sup> *Lose Blätter*. I. p. 35; 136. — *Reflexionen Kants*. II. p. 307 (No. 1071). — *Kritik der reinen Vernunft* 1st ed.

Had Kant remained here, he would not have asserted more than he could prove. But then he would, to be sure, have had no ground to set up his sharp difference between category and idea, since it would then show itself that the category already poses ideal demands which real knowledge always satisfies only imperfectly.<sup>60</sup> Kant was carried beyond the goal by his confidence in the «Copernican» thought, in which (as will be mentioned later) the discovery of 1769 consisted. It gave him the courage to undertake the synthetic construction which only a few years before had stood for him as a distant goal. From the *archetype* and the *presumption* he passed without further ado to the *law*, as though this could be derived from those. He regards *real* knowledge as given with the *concept* of knowledge: the old ontological train of thought has here outwitted its great opponent! The transcendental deduction, which had cost him so much trouble, and of which he was so proud, was in reality epistemological alchemy. But just as the alchemists often, in their search for the philosopher's stone, discovered along the way new chemical relations, so Kant, in his eager striving to give an absolute solution of Hume's problem, came to make valuable contributions to the understanding of the nature of our knowledge.

16. Only a single point shall still be brought forward to illuminate Kant's analytic method. He proceeds, as we have seen (§ 12), from the assumption that the constant elements in our experience must derive *merely* from our cognitive activity itself and be *only* an expression of its laws. Had Kant gone more fully into the analysis that led him to set up the forms, he would also have had to come to test more closely the justification of this assumption. He proceeds, after all, from the very first from the assumption that consciousness, the knowing subject, is not the only existing thing, but is only a member of the whole of existence and stands in a reciprocal relation with the rest of what exists. The manner in which the subject apprehends existence can then not be determined merely by its own nature, but must *also* be determined by the nature of what exists.

There are several unnoticed intimations in Kant in this direction. In the «Kritik der reinen Vernunft», first edition (p. 358), there is talk of «the something that lies at the foundation of the outer phenomena and affects our sense in such a way that it obtains the representations of space, matter, figure, etc.». And on the occasion of the question how intuition of space is at all possible in a thinking subject, it is remarked that to this only this much can be said, that the representations of outer phenomena have their cause

---

p. 126; 2nd ed. p. 303.

<sup>60</sup>Already *Salomon Maimon* demonstrated this. «Für mich ist Erfahrung im strengen Sinne kein in der Anschauung darstellbarer Begriff, sondern eine Idee». *Kritische Untersuchungen*. Leipzig 1797. p. 154. — «Die kritische Philosophie kann nur hypothetisch philosophiren». *Die Kategorien des Aristoteles*. Berlin 1794. p. 133.

in the thing in itself («the transcendental object») (ibid. p. 393). The manner in which I apprehend a thing need not, after all, at all resemble the very thing that calls forth the apprehension (the sensation or the spatial intuition) in me — it is said in *Prolegomena* p. 64. Spatial intuition is, it is said in the second edition of the *Critique of Reason* (p. 66, 69), determined by the relation of the object to the subject. The clearest statements are found in some places in the «Dialectic». It is impossible, it is said, to answer the question «*why the transcendental object gives our sensible intuition precisely only spatial intuition and not another kind of intuition*». «Many forces in nature, which manifest their existence by certain effects, are and remain unfathomable for us; for we cannot trace them far enough by observation. *The transcendental object lying at the foundation of the phenomena, and with it the ground of why our sensibility has precisely these definite highest conditions and not others, are and remain unfathomable for us, although the matter itself is otherwise given, only not seen through*» (2nd ed. p. 585; 631 f.). — In these last places the ground of spatial intuition is even quite predominantly ascribed to the thing in itself.

From these intimations it is seen that Kant derived not only the material but also the form from the thing in itself. But when this is so, it is unjustified when he so often sets up a dilemma that offers the choice between letting the object determine the representation and the representation determine the object. In his own theory both are in reality presupposed. Kant cannot therefore consistently be the strict apriorist he will be. There is a fundamental presupposition that he has not brought forward, and on which nevertheless his whole «system of principles» rests: namely, that the thing in itself acts constantly. For if this is not the case, then — even if the nature of the subject be presupposed unchangeable — the constant elements in experience, which are the real foundation for Kant's whole epistemological edifice, could change, and the principles would then change too. — From this side too it shows itself that «the critical philosophy can only philosophise hypothetically». Kant's assumption that he could carry through a philosophy about the phenomena without needing to set up any presupposition whatever about the thing in itself was incorrect. His first critics already drew attention to the fact that when he uses the concepts thing, existence, and cause about it, it is nevertheless not *absolutely* unknown. But it must be added that he also presupposes that it acts in a regular manner.

Kant believed himself to have furnished a proof of the validity of the causal proposition, something from which Wolff had come off most unhappily. While Wolff would derive it from the principle of contradiction, Kant grounds it as the presupposition of

the possibility of experience.<sup>61</sup> Kant's proof rests on the assumption that the concept of cause is one of the subjective forms without which experience in the strict sense does not come into being. But just as little as the circumstance that we apprehend outer phenomena in the form of space could be derived from the nature of the subject alone, just as little does Kant regard it as independent of the thing in itself that we apprehend phenomena as causes and effects. This is seen from a statement such as this: «Dem transscendentalen Objecte können wir *allen Umfang und Zusammenhang* unserer möglichen Wahrnehmungen zuschreiben ... Die Erscheinungen sind, *ihm gemäss*, ... *gegeben*».<sup>62</sup> Here, then, the phenomena are said, not only as regards material but also as regards form, to be in agreement with the thing in itself, in that their *connection* too is referred to it. The thing in itself must thus be just as constant in its action on the subject as the connection among the phenomena is. And here we stand, then, at a *fundamental presupposition about the thing in itself which Kant never formulated*. It shows itself that to «the possibility of experience», which bears Kant's whole theory of knowledge, there belongs more than the subjective conditions. Hereby both apriorism and phenomenalism are limited. The possibility of anticipating the phenomena and the necessity of distinguishing between these and the thing in itself are limited in a significant manner. In particular, the necessity falls away of excluding the causal principle from validity for the thing in itself. Although the strict, a priori proof for the causal proposition falls away, there is gained the advantage that the great difficulty which lay in Kant's assumption of the thing in itself as cause of the sensations falls away at the same time. At the same time as the system is altered in an empirical and realist direction, it also loses its great inconsistency.

### III.

## Theory and Practice

17. We return once more to Kant's standpoint in 1762 and the following years, in order to consider it from a new side. Kant had seen the necessity of a reformation of philosophy and expected salvation for the present along the path of analysis. But when so much stood undecided and unfinished, and when, with respect to some of the fundamental concepts (e.g. the concept of cause), we stood before the inexplicable, then the fund of theoretical philosophy that Kant at this time had at his disposal for positive presentation cannot have

---

<sup>61</sup>*Kritik der reinen Vernunft*. 2nd ed. p. 264.

<sup>62</sup>*Ibid.* p. 522 f.

been great. In his effort «rather to have a thorough philosophy than a comprehensive one» he had made a clean sweep. Even in the «Beweisgrund», the most constructive writing of this time, he declares that the intention was not to give a real demonstration, and that God's existence did not need to be proved either. In confidence that religious faith had an entirely different foundation than demonstration, he overturned the whole basis of natural theology. And in a similar manner he proceeded in «Träume» against spiritualist psychology. The cosmological antinomies seem at the same time to have played a great role for him in his attempts to find the limits of knowledge. The material for the part of the «Kritik der reinen Vernunft» that he called Dialectic, and which was the part that made not the least impression at the work's appearance, was thus in essentials finished.

Kant's philosophy was bound thereby to acquire a certain negative stamp, in opposition to the dogmatism bursting with positivity. Kant was fully conscious of this. He uses of his philosophy the expression «philosophy of ignorance», also «negative philosophy». He finds this philosophy the most difficult of all, because it must go back to the sources of knowledge in order to be able to ground its non-knowledge.

«Where error is tempting and at the same time dangerous, there negative cognitions and criteria are more important than positive ones and often constitute the real object of our science ... Socrates had a negative philosophy as regards speculation, namely concerning the worthlessness of much supposed science and concerning the limits of our knowledge. The negative part of education is the most important (Rousseau).»<sup>63</sup>

These references to Socrates and to Rousseau are characteristic of Kant's standpoint at this time. Socrates' knowledge was, after all, a knowledge that he knew nothing, a knowledge grounded on clear insight into what was required in order to know something. And Socrates also warned against unfinished concepts and sought, by all-sided discussion, to lead to correct determinations of concepts. As regards Rousseau, Kant draws in the cited statement a parallel between his «negative education» and his own negative philosophy. By negative education Rousseau understood «an education that strives to perfect the organs, the instruments of our knowledge, before it gives us knowledge itself, and which prepares for reason by exercising the senses. Negative education does not fold its hands in its lap, far from it: it imparts no virtues, but it prevents vices; it teaches not truth, but it prevents errors.» It is grounded particularly by the necessity of coming to know the nature and character of the individual, as they unfold of their own accord, before one intervenes in accordance with general and handed-down rules. It is, in its

---

<sup>63</sup>*Reflexionen Kants*. II. p. 44 f. (Nos. 148–151).

care to keep error out and to find the limits of the individual's peculiar nature, a difficult art — the art: *tout faire en ne faisant rien*.<sup>64</sup> — In several respects the critical philosophy, according to the best and most justified in its spirit, has its prototype in Rousseau's doctrine of negative education. In both cases negation and critique serve to protect the positive unfolding of life, whereas dogmatism, both in philosophy and in pedagogy, is eager to intervene and to fix or regulate everything according to its «eternal truths».

It is well known to what a high degree Rousseau's writings interested Kant. When he got *Émile*, it kept him back from his usual walk. But had Kant's notes and additions to his «Beobachtungen über das Schöne und Erhabene» not at the last moment been rescued out of a grocer's pile of waste paper,<sup>65</sup> one would not have known how deeply personal this expression was. It brought about for Kant an entirely new foundation for the valuation of human beings and human relations. Hitherto Kant had been an optimist, had regarded intellectual development as the highest and seen progress decided by it. From Rousseau he learned a measure of human worth that to a certain degree was independent of intellectual development. He now learned that the rabble is not to be despised merely because «it knows nothing». He «learned to honour human beings». And he praised Rousseau for having brought forth man's deeply hidden nature beneath the forms of civilisation, which all too often conceal it.<sup>66</sup> — Here, then, there was given a factual foundation for human life, whereby this became independent of how things went with the scientific knowledge of existence and its source. This was for Kant a great support, since he had just grounded his critique of natural theology and of spiritualist psychology. If the learned lost some favourite doctrines, then «the great, to us most estimable multitude»<sup>67</sup> lost nothing.

18. But it is with this Rousseauian influence as with the Humean one: were it not secured by external testimony, we would in Kant's writings find no compelling occasion to presuppose it. In itself one could very well, from Kant's train of thought as it unfolded in the year 1762 and the following years, have understood how he came to the distinction between theory and practice, which from this time onward — thus long before he fixed it in his *Critiques of Reason* — played so great a role in him.

With the critique of the proofs of God's existence the duality of the motives that had led to the construction of the concept of God was bound to come to light as well. The one group of motives was of a purely theoretical kind and consisted essentially

---

<sup>64</sup>*Lettre à M. de Beaumont* (Petits chefs d'œuvres de J. J. Rousseau. Paris 1859. p. 313). — *Émile*. Livre II. (Paris 1851. p. 80 f.; 116.)

<sup>65</sup>*Sämmtl. Werke*. Ed. Rosenkranz u. Schubert XI, 1. p. 218 f.

<sup>66</sup>*Sämmtl. Werke*. Ed. Rosenkranz u. Schubert XI, 1. p. 240. 248.

<sup>67</sup>*Kritik der reinen Vernunft*. 2nd ed. Preface p. XXXIII.

in the urge to bring the causal series to a close, to let the working thoughts come to rest in the contemplation of a being «grounded in itself». The other group was of an aesthetic-ethical kind, and consisted essentially in an urge to concentrate in one concept everything valuable in the world. By the fusion of both groups of motives there arose the dogmatic philosophy's concept of God as *ens realissimum*, the sum-total of all reality, such that reality meant the same as perfection, in that only such properties as express negation and limitation were to be excluded. Already in the «Beweisgrund» (I, 4, 3) Kant opposed this confusion of the concepts reality and perfection. Perfection expresses a valuation, which is made by a feeling and willing being: it can thus not be an absolute property. And in the treatise on negative magnitudes (III, 2nd remark) Kant draws attention to the fact that, since displeasure is just as positive and real as pleasure, one cannot make the sum-total of all reality identical with the highest perfection. This from the metaphysical side. From the psychological side the matter is treated in the treatise on the distinctness of the principles, where it is said (IV, 2): «Only in our day has one begun to see that the capacity to discern the true is *cognition*, the capacity to feel the good is *feeling*, and that they must not be confused with one another. Just as there are unanalysable concepts of the true, that is, of what is found in the objects of knowledge considered in and for themselves, so too is there an unanalysable feeling of the good, which is never found in a thing in and for itself, but always in relation to a feeling being. Practical philosophy has its principles, just as theoretical philosophy has its own, and their origin is still to be investigated, toward which Hutcheson and others have made a good beginning.» — In «Nachricht von der Einrichtung seiner Vorlesungen» it is stated that correct moral judgments can be passed by the human heart without the circumlocution of demonstrations, by what one calls sentiment. Reference is made to Shaftesbury, Hutcheson, and Hume as those who have come furthest in seeking out the first grounds of morality. It is Rousseau's predecessors that Kant here refers to. Of Rousseau himself we are reminded both when he demands, as the foundation of ethics, a study of human nature, which is easily mistaken on account of the changes that external relations bring about, and when the task is set: to decide what perfection belongs to man in the state of *natural* simplicity and in the state of *wise* simplicity.<sup>68</sup> But only because we know by other means of Rousseau's influence on Kant do these traces become clear.

Kant was, as is seen, himself on a path that was bound to lead him to sympathise with Rousseau. The latter's influence has probably, like Hume's, been awakening, accelerating, has led to a quicker and more definite unfolding of thoughts that were already budding,

---

<sup>68</sup>This opposition Kant treated far later, with special reference to Rousseau's various writings, in his treatise: *Muthmasslicher Anfang des Menschengeschlechts* (1786).

but has not consisted in a positive imparting of something that did not lie as a possibility in his own preceding development. Of not least importance has it been that Rousseau taught that human beings, in the intellectual domain as well as in the material, have many imagined needs. *Nous pouvons être hommes sans être savants!* — *Jeune homme, sachez être ignorant!* — says the Savoyard Vicar to his disciple. When Kant now stood at the break with dogmatic speculation and had overturned the foundation for natural theology and spiritualist psychology, he was bound to find a support in Rousseau's train of thought. In the concluding section of «Träume eines Geistersehers» this is clearly traced. After his critique of the speculative and the visionary attempts to gain access to or insight into the spirit-world he exclaims: «How much is there that I do not understand!» — but adds at once: «And how much is there that I do not need!»

The emancipation of ethics from metaphysics and theology was herewith given. But Kant acknowledges not merely a foundation for the ethical independent of theory. He goes a step further, in that he states that it would even be very questionable if moral action were motivated merely by the belief in another world. Instead of building morality on religion, one should conversely build religion on morality. Those who would know all about the other world must wait until they come there. For the present they know that they are to do their duty, and more they do not need to know. Kant ends his ingenious work as Voltaire ends his *Candide*: Let us go out into the garden and work!

On this point too, then, there is continuity between the earlier works and the later. The concluding section of «Träume» is developed further twenty years afterward in «Kritik der praktischen Vernunft». And that the insight gained was held fast in the meantime is seen from the fact that in the Dissertation (§ 9) a distinction is expressly drawn between the highest theoretical and the highest practical concept.

19. With respect to the foundation on which Kant built the ethics independent of metaphysics and theology, considerable variations took place in the course of his development, though in such a way that there is a certain fundamental stamp common to the various stages through which his ethical conception passes.

In «Beobachtungen über das Schöne und Erhabene» [Observations on the Feeling of the Beautiful and the Sublime] (1764 [i.e. 1763]) true virtue is already made dependent on definite principles, in opposition to «adopted virtue», which rests on immediate natural inclinations such as compassion and benevolence. What is characteristic of this first ethical standpoint of Kant's is that the principles on which true virtue rests are «the consciousness of a feeling that lives in every human breast, ... the feeling of the beauty

and dignity of human nature.»<sup>69</sup> By the principled emphasis on the significance of the general principles Kant distinguishes himself from the English moralists, on whom he otherwise relies in these years. But the principles themselves are assumed to develop in that one becomes conscious of one's feeling of the beauty and dignity of human nature. This feeling is thus the moral feeling. In it, as is developed in «*Träume eines Geistersehers*», the will of the individual is bound to the general will: «A secret power compels us to direct our aim also toward the good of others or according to a foreign will, even though it often happens unwillingly and in high degree conflicts with the selfish inclination; — and the point where the directional lines of our drives converge thus lies not merely in us, but there are also in the will of others outside us forces that move us ... We see ourselves, then, in the most secret motives, dependent on the rule of the general will, and from this there springs, in the world of thinking beings, a moral unity and a systematic constitution according to purely spiritual laws.»<sup>70</sup>

Kant's ethics here stands on purely psychological ground. What proclaims itself in the individual mood and in the individual case is subordinated to what is demanded by regard for the whole world to which the individual belongs. The enlarged feeling, conditioned by the most circumspect experience, we become conscious of in general principles and thereafter control the emotion and urge of the moment. By this subordination of the limited under the universal the ethical feeling acquires the character of the sublime, and it is from this side that Kant comes to treat of it in «*Beobachtungen*».

20. But Kant did not (unfortunately) remain at this connection of psychology and ethics. His analysis led him, in the ethical domain as well as in the epistemological, to distinguish sharply between reason and sensibility and between form and material. It even seems as if this distinction in the ethical domain was found by him earlier than in the theoretical domain.<sup>71</sup> The psychological-genetic conception, which in «*Beobachtungen*» and «*Träume*» he still regarded as compatible with ethics, he pushed aside, in order that the ethical might have its source in pure reason. The influence of the dilemma he now sets up between reason and sensibility is that all feeling is reckoned to the sensible part of our nature,<sup>72</sup> to the material, the empirical, that by which we are passive, not self-active. In diametrical opposition to the standpoint in «*Beobachtungen*», now the principles are to determine the feeling, not conversely. The moral feeling now becomes

<sup>69</sup>*Beobachtungen über das Gefühl des Schönen und Erhabenen*. Königsberg 1764. p. 23.

<sup>70</sup>*Träume eines Geistersehers*. I, 2. (Kehrbach's edition, p. 23.)

<sup>71</sup>Letter to M. Hertz of 21 February 1772: «In der Unterscheidung des Sinnlichen vom Intellektualen in der Moral und den daraus entspringenden Grundsätzen hatte ich es *schon vorher* [i.e. before the Dissertation of 1770] ziemlich weit gebracht.» Cf. letter to Herder, 9 May 1767, to Lambert 2 Sept. 1770.

<sup>72</sup>«Alles Gefühl ist sinnlich.» *Kritik der praktischen Vernunft*. I, 1, 3 (Kehrbach's edition, p. 92).

the feeling of respect determined by the consciousness of the universal law. Respect for other personalities is grounded by the fact that they are organs for the moral law, for the same law that we ourselves feel within us. And while Kant in «Beobachtungen» named the feeling for the beauty of human nature alongside the feeling for its dignity, this feeling of beauty has later fallen away entirely from his ethics. This feeling presupposed a harmony between the elements of human nature, which Kant, on account of his sharp opposition between reason and sensibility, could no longer assume. Therefore he was so doubtful about Schiller's juxtaposition of «Anmuth und Würde» [grace and dignity]. Although it was his opinion that duty should be exercised with joy and gladness, there must nevertheless be no sensible elements involved therein. The gladness shall be conditioned exclusively by the very unfolding of the inner power of the rational will, not co-conditioned by the harmonious relation to the sensible nature. In any case grace must not be placed before dignity; for even though the consciousness of duty may have grace as its companion, it must nevertheless not take any account of it. The mood that the consciousness of duty awakens has the character of the sublime, not of the beautiful, and where ethical work is concerned, the Graces must keep at a respectful distance. Only when Hercules has subdued the monsters can he move among the Muses and the Graces.<sup>73</sup>

Sharp as the opposition is between Kant's earlier ethical standpoint and the definitive one, we can nevertheless, with the help of the Kantian notes published in recent years, trace the transition from the one standpoint to the other.

21. When Kant, by his own statement, learned from Rousseau «to honour human beings», and when he (in «Beobachtungen») conceived the moral feeling as the feeling of humanity's dignity, on what, then, in his eyes, did this honour and dignity rest? — There emerges here, early in Kant's ethical conception, a chief trait that never left it, although he explained it philosophically in very different ways. It was the value he attached to the capacity to subordinate the individual and changing under the general and unchangeable, impressions and moods under the principle fixed in spite of all vicissitudes, the passively received under spiritual activity. This trait made him, already in «Beobachtungen», reckon the moral feeling under the feeling of the sublime, just as he also later (see both «Kritik der praktischen Vernunft» and «Kritik der Urtheilskraft») found a close kinship between these two feelings, though in such a way that he no longer reckoned the moral feeling under the feeling of the sublime, but rather took the reverse path, in that he

---

<sup>73</sup>Kant's answer to Schiller's «Anmuth u. Würde» is found in his «Religion innerhalb der Grenzen der blossen Vernunft». 2nd ed. p. 10 f. — Cf. also notes written after the reading of Schiller's treatise in «Thalia»: *Lose Blätter* I. p. 120; 126 f.

interpreted the feeling of the sublime by assuming a co-operation of the moral feeling.

For the understanding of the change in Kant's ethical theory, which seems to have taken place in the interval between 1766 (*Träume*) and 1770 (*Dissertation*), perhaps the following consideration may serve. — The more that relation of opposition between the individual, changing, passive on the one side, and the universal, fixed and active on the other side, was emphasised, the more there had to become, for Kant, something unsatisfactory in conceiving the principles as having arisen through our becoming conscious of the moral feeling. They thereby seem to become dependent on contingencies. A quite certain starting point for the ethical would by contrast be obtained if the activity of reason were posited as the first and original, and feeling were regarded only as its product. Thus the relation between principle and feeling had to be reversed if the direction in which Kant's ethics already moved in «*Beobachtungen*» and «*Träume*» was to be carried through absolutely. And that this tendency had to be strengthened by Kant's untiring work at distinguishing between «the pure» and «the empirical» follows of itself. It was perhaps not even free of the fact that the concept of the pure acquired a moral tinge in Kant's eyes. At least there is an ambiguity in the manner in which he from this time onward uses the expression «*Sinnlichkeit*» of all elements in human nature with the exception of reason.

He now distanced himself from the English moral philosophers, to whom he had earlier referred, and regarded it as a great fault that they traced the moral criteria back to the feeling of pleasure and displeasure. He saw no difference in principle between Shaftesbury's and Epicurus' standpoint (*Dissertatio* § 9), something over which Mendelssohn (letter to Kant 23 Dec. 1770) already rightly complained. The moral concepts are now to be known not by experience, but by pure reason, and moral philosophy belongs, as regards the first principles of judging (*principia dijudicandi prima*), to pure philosophy (*Diss.* § 7; 9). — How Kant at this stage more closely conceived the grounding of the ethical is not known. Yet there are statements and drafts that show that prior to the ethical theory he developed in «*Grundlegung zur Metaphysik der Sitten*» and in «*Kritik der praktischen Vernunft*» there goes a theory that to a certain degree forms a transitional link between the older psychologising and the later rationalist ethics.

22. In the «*Reflexionen*» there is found, from a moment that does not lie far from the genesis of the «*Dissertation*», even if it lies, in the editor's view, prior to it, a determination of the concept of *practical idealism*, according to which this consists in the fact that happiness does not depend on the external world, or more fully: «that the world is only what we make it, that in a glad mind it has a bright, in a melancholy mind

a dark appearance, that the grounds of a happy condition are to be sought in ourselves.» And this practical idealism is expressly called «not the idealism of fancy, but of reason, of wisdom.»<sup>74</sup>

Not a little akin to the practical idealism thus determined is the conception that comes forth in a moral-philosophical draft in the «loose leaves of Kant's papers» published by R. Reicke. Here morality is defined as «*the idea of freedom as the principle of happiness*». «It is true that virtue has the advantage that it would bring about the greatest welfare by means of what nature offers. But its high value consists not in the fact that it, as it were, serves as a means. *That it is we ourselves who produce it as authors* without regard to the empirical conditions (which can give only particular maxims of living), — that it brings self-contentment with it, — this is its inner value». «Only he is in a position to be happy whose use of his will does not conflict with the conditions for happiness that nature gives him ... Happiness is really not the greatest sum of pleasure, but pleasure in the consciousness of my own power to be content (*Selbstmacht zufrieden zu sein*); it is at least the most important formal condition for happiness, though there are still others required *materialiter* (as by experience)». «Happiness must derive from an *a priori ground* that reason approves». «Freedom is a capacity to do and to refrain independently of empirical grounds ... But I am free only from the compulsion of sensibility, not from the limiting laws of reason ... The unboundedness with which I can will what is against my very will, so that I cannot count on myself with certainty, must in the highest degree awaken displeasure in me. It is known *a priori* that *a law is needed by which freedom is limited in such a way that the will can agree with itself*. This law I cannot betray without conflicting with my reason, which alone can fix the *practical unity of the will* according to principles». «It is freedom according to the laws of thoroughgoing agreement with itself that constitutes the value and dignity of personality.»<sup>75</sup>

The ethical standpoint that lies at the foundation of these statements differs from that which appears in «*Beobachtungen*» by its rationalist and individualist character. It

<sup>74</sup>*Reflexionen Kants*. II. p. 319. (Nos. 1116; 1119.)

<sup>75</sup>*Lose Blätter* I. p. 10–15. This fragment was by the editor, the librarian Rudolph Reicke, assigned to the years 80 or 90. Since it was clear to me from the content that it must date from a time prior to «*Grundlegung zur Metaphysik der Sitten*», which appeared in 1785, I applied to the editor for information concerning the grounds that had determined his dating of the manuscript. Mr. Reicke has been so good as to investigate the matter anew and has, in a private letter of 10 Nov. 1892, informed me that there is nothing in the way of the fragment's dating from the 1770s, but that he would nevertheless, by the handwriting, rather assign it to the 1780s; to the 1790s he now considers it impossible to assign it. Possibly it then came into being at the end of the 1770s or the beginning of the 1780s. I would be inclined to believe that it was composed some time before the last redaction of «*Kritik der reinen Vernunft*», since it does not yet have the pronounced imperative ethics that «*Kritik d. r. V.*» already hints at, any more than the doctrine of the intelligible character.

finds the highest in the activity by which the individual can be the creator of his own happiness, and finds as the essential law for this activity that the individual must act with full consistency, in agreement with himself. There is here made an essential step in the direction of laying the chief weight on the formal side of the ethical. The ethical law shall abstract from the content, spring from the free activity itself, and can then be only its self-limitation<sup>76</sup> through the necessity of preserving the agreement with itself. Kant had here reached a chief point in his ethics: the inner relation between action and law, a relation which, in his conception, could become the right one only when the law was purely formal; only then could it be a priori, abstract from all definite content. In genetic respect, therefore, that moral-philosophical fragment is exceedingly interesting. A problem it forms by its eudaemonistic and individualist character, which places it in opposition both to the earlier and to the later standpoint. The relation between virtue and happiness, which for Kant's later ethics became so difficult a problem that only religious postulates could resolve it, contained, according to this «practical idealism», no difficulty in principle. The external goods must be given up, or one must in any case prepare oneself for resignation toward them; but this is outweighed by the feeling of freedom and power that here stands as the highest good, just as it is determined by what here is the highest virtue. The standpoint in the fragment forms a swinging-arc in Kant's moral-philosophical development of an analogous kind to «the Dissertation» in his epistemological development. Of greatest importance in both places was the sharp distinction between form and content, a priori and a posteriori. It became determining for the future. The sharper form in which this opposition appears in Kant's definitive ethics brought with it, among other things, also that opposition between virtue and happiness which could be resolved only along the path of the religious postulate.

If one would imagine what, from the standpoint of the fragment, may have led Kant over to his definitive ethics, then it lies near at hand to refer to how he, in his theoretical philosophy, had reached the point of determining the universally valid as that which agrees with the nature of all rational subjects. By analogy herewith the moral law became not merely an expression of the individual's agreement with himself, but of the preservation of the connection of reason in the whole, of the individual's connection with the whole intelligible world. Thus it is said in a note from the 1770s: «The intelligible world has laws according to which I am fit for any world, not merely for this one, for the world of sense, but no matter how my nature and external nature, as

---

<sup>76</sup>The fragment's expression about the limitation of freedom might recall «Kritik der reinen Vernunft» 1st ed. p. 569, where there is talk of «the principle by which reason sets limits to the freedom that is in itself lawless», and where the Stoic sage is mentioned as an ethical ideal.

well as the society in which I live, are arranged ... It accords with the rules of prudence *when this [i.e. prudence] is extended.*»<sup>77</sup> These last words seem to hint at a development from the earlier rationalist standpoint to the definitive one. By means of the idea of the intelligible world Kant has, despite the formalism, succeeded in giving his rationalist ethics a social character such as his first, psychologically-motivated ethics had by its very genesis.

But yet another, quite different train of thought has probably also co-operated in this transition, and that a train of thought which precisely had a psychological-historical character and so far might seem to accord little with the rationalist path on which Kant had entered. In the beginning of the 1780s Kant was strongly occupied with the thought that the human natural endowments, insofar as they concern the use of reason, come to full development only in the species, not in the individual, since the development of reason requires far longer time than the individual's life-span. The goal for human development can therefore not be an individual one, but must be a universal goal, a goal for all, not merely a goal for this or that individual. This train of thought lies at the foundation of Kant's remarkable treatise «*Idee zu einer allgemeinen Geschichte in weltbürgerlicher Absicht*», which appeared in 1784, the year before «*Grundlegung zur Metaphysik der Sitten*». In the cited train of thought one must in part seek the explanation of the fact that Kant now conceives the moral law not as the formal rule within the individual's isolated striving, but as the rule that brings the individual striving into agreement with the striving of all rational beings. It is, unconsciously for Kant himself, an idea drawn from psychological-historical experience that has given his definitive ethics its universalist character alongside the rationalist character. The very universal formula that Kant makes into the moral principle contains, as it were, a recollection of a society of individuals whose wills it is a matter of bringing into harmony with one another; it is really an idealisation of the laws of intercourse among personal beings that experience shows us.<sup>78</sup> The great value of Kant's formula rests precisely — however much Kant himself would deny it — on this its crypto-empirical origin.

23. Finally, renewed investigation and analysis of the immediate ethical feeling has also exercised its great influence in the genesis of Kant's definitive ethics. Just as analysis and construction could be shown to co-operate in the grounding of Kant's theory of knowledge, so we also find both methods in the grounding of his ethics. It is precisely the after-effect of this immediate contact with the ethical in practice that gives Kant's ethical

---

<sup>77</sup>*Reflexionen Kants*. II. p. 336. (No. 1158.)

<sup>78</sup>Cf. what I have already remarked about this in my treatise «*Om Grundlaget for den humane Etik*» (Copenhagen 1876). p. 52.

writings (especially «Grundlegung zur Metaphysik der Sitten») so fresh and vigorous a colour. In «Grundlegung» Kant precisely makes his way to the proper moral philosophy through analysis of «the common moral knowledge of reason» — little as he otherwise will let psychological experience have any influence whatever on the ethical ideas. By this renewed analysis he then found, as a chief trait of the ethical, that the individual feels himself bound in his inner being to a law that is at once the expression of his own innermost essence and orders him as a member of a great realm of reason. The moral criterion now becomes whether the maxim that the action expresses can be made into a *universal* maxim. This doctrine forms an analogy to the doctrine of the law-governed connection of phenomena as the expression of real experience.

To the law corresponds the force. From the moral law as a fact proclaiming itself in all consciousness of duty Kant infers the pure self-activity of reason, which he calls freedom (in one of the several meanings in which he unfortunately uses this word). For freedom, self-activity, cannot be immediately apprehended, and just as little can it be derived from experience. The moral law we become immediately conscious of, and it leads to the assumption of freedom as the capacity to act independently of all sensible conditions.<sup>79</sup> The moral law is the expression of reason's autonomy.<sup>80</sup> By obeying the law of his own essence the individual at the same time obeys the general law of the spiritual world.

Herewith Kant's ethics differs from the earlier rationalist ethics, as it was developed by the «Intellectualists» of the 17th century and by Price. When these grounded the ethical on reason, they meant thereby the objective, rational connection of things, which man apprehends by his reason and thereafter bows before. Reason as a human faculty here had, as Fr. Jodl aptly puts it,<sup>81</sup> a merely receptive role to carry out, namely to appropriate the reason that was assumed to be given in the relations of the world, and to apply it in one's action. Kant's practical reason is by contrast, like his theoretical reason, an expression of man's own innermost essence, a sum-total of laws for man's spiritual activity. The profound thought in Kant's definitive ethics is that man, by becoming conscious of the moral law, becomes conscious of himself as a citizen of two different worlds that meet in his person: «The moral ought is the subject's own willing as a member of an intelligible world and is thought only as an ought insofar as the subject at

---

<sup>79</sup>*Kritik der praktischen Vernunft*, § 6 remark (Kehrbach's ed. p. 53). Cf. *Lose Blätter* I, p. 120. — When in individual places, e.g. *Grundlegung* p. 108, it is said that «that in man which is pure activity comes immediately to consciousness», the word «immediately» must, according to the context, be understood as opposed to «durch Afficirung der Sinne».

<sup>80</sup>«Das moralische Gesetz ist das Gesetz der Autonomie der reinen practischen Vernunft». *Kritik der praktischen Vernunft*. Kehrbach's ed. p. 53.

<sup>81</sup>*Geschichte der Ethik in der neueren Philosophie*. I. Munich 1882. p. 221.

the same time regards itself as a member of the world of sense.»<sup>82</sup> In strict rationalist form Kant has here developed anew a thought that came forth in more empirical form in «Beobachtungen», when appeal was made to the dignity of human nature. It is this dignity for which he believed he had to seek a deeper grounding than psychology could give. The idea of man's dignity is the continuous element in Kant's ethics; what varies is the grounding.

Despite its exalted character, Kant's rationalist ethics nevertheless rests, when considered as a member of his critical philosophy, on a great inconsistency. The parallel between the theoretical and the practical reason is not maintained. The enemy whom Kant combats with the weapons of critique he sees as highly different in the two domains. In the theoretical domain it is speculation, the transcendent use of the concepts, that is to be combated. «Kritik der reinen Vernunft» corresponds to its name, for it is really a critique of reason. But «Kritik der praktischen Vernunft» is not at all a critique of reason's application in the ethical-practical domain, as one would suppose from the title and from the analogy with that principal work. And Kant really admits it himself. The task here is, he says (Einleitung von der Idee einer Kritik der praktischen Vernunft), «to keep the empirically conditioned reason away from the presumption of wishing to provide exclusively the determining ground of the will.»<sup>83</sup> By contrast he does not discuss the presumption of pure reason to wish to be the exclusive determining ground, but assumes precisely that the ethical consists solely in this. He does not admit that there could be a critical investigation to undertake concerning reason's justification in the practical domain, and that notwithstanding that he himself strongly emphasises the inexplicability in the fact that pure reason determines the will of a «sensibly» conditioned being. — It avenges itself here that the psychological foundation has been pushed aside.

## IV.

### The Copernican Principle

24. I return to Kant's theoretical philosophy in order to investigate how the turning point in 1769, which brought about the proper grounding of the critical philosophy, can be inserted as a member in Kant's continuous development, and how the consequences were gradually drawn from this turning point.

What had been reached in 1762 was the recognition that the concepts with which

---

<sup>82</sup>*Grundlegung zur Metaphysik der Sitten*. 3rd ed. Riga 1792. p. 113.

<sup>83</sup>Cf. more closely on this: A. Fouillée: *Critique des systèmes de Morale contemporains*. Paris 1883. p. 129–142.

one had hitherto operated in philosophy were useless, unfinished; analysis was not carried through; of philosophical construction there could only, in a distant future, be any talk. Kant had not given up the hope of a concluding theoretical philosophy that gave information about questions lying beyond the domain of experience. But he turned with mockery and irony against the dogmatists, who, unperturbed by all difficulties, built their systems and decided all problems. His attention was directed toward method and toward the determination of the limits of knowledge, and he had already begun to speak of a critique of reason. In order to find the limits of rational knowledge he operated with the method of antinomies, in that in the contradiction between two trains of thought each grounded for itself he saw a proof that reason had ventured too far out. «I sought», he says,<sup>84</sup> «something that was certain, if not with respect to the objects, then at least with respect to the nature and limits of knowledge. I found gradually that many of the propositions we regard as objective are in reality subjective, that is, contain the conditions under which alone we discern or comprehend the objects.» From the content of consciousness Kant thus came to turn his attention to conscious activity itself and to make it the object of his analysis. Of the procedure in this analysis there has been talk above (§ 6).

It is through such an analysis that he came not only to distinguish between form and material, but also between intuiting and thinking. Thus it is said in «Prolegomena» (p. 119): «In an investigation of the pure (containing nothing empirical) elements of human knowledge it succeeded for me only after long reflection to distinguish and single out the pure elementary concepts of sensibility (space and time) from the elementary concepts of the understanding.» — At the same time there dawned on him the conviction that in those elementary concepts of sensibility we have only an expression for the forms in which, according to the nature of our sense-faculty, we apprehend things, not for the things' own essence, and that it is by this alone that mathematical knowledge of nature is possible. These were the important steps taken in 1769 and developed in the Dissertation of 1770.

25. From the year before there is a little interesting treatise by Kant: «Vom ersten Grunde des Unterschiedes der Gegenden im Raume» [On the First Ground of the Distinction of Regions in Space]. He here defends Newton's conception, according to which absolute space lies at the foundation of every individual determination of place, against Leibniz's conception of space as a property or a relation determined by the nature and action of things. He relies especially on the fact that with bodies entirely alike and yet

---

<sup>84</sup>*Reflexionen Kants*. II. p. 4 (No. 3).

incongruent (such as, for example, the right and left hand) one cannot determine the place of the parts without taking account of the space outside the bodies. From this he infers that space as a whole lies at the foundation in the determination of the individual place.

In the course of the next year (1768–69) it must then have dawned on Kant that «absolute space» was not anything objective and real, but a subjective form, a schema for our apprehension of things. Here, then, we have an example of the transposition from objective reality to subjective condition of which he speaks in the utterance cited above. It is in this connection of interest to note that the same argument which Kant in the little treatise of 1768 used to prove Newton's conception of space against Leibniz's, he later uses (Prolegomena § 13)<sup>85</sup> to prove his own doctrine of the subjectivity of space against the usual assumption of its objectivity. It is then clear that Newton's conception had been for him a station on his path. It did not lie so far off, for one who, to so high a degree as Kant, had occupied himself with the study of Newton, to make the transposition from the objective to the subjective. Newton conceived space as *sensorium dei*, a thought that is seen to have occupied Kant much.<sup>86</sup> It was then merely a matter of putting *sensorium hominis* in the place of *sensorium dei*, which, for one occupied with investigating the general nature and mode of operation of human knowledge, could likewise not lie so far off. — The after-effects of Newton's conception one finds in the psychological difficulties in which Kant's theory of space entangles itself by retaining the determination of space as infinite and yet conceiving it as the form of the sense-intuition operative in experience, whose object must always be finite — difficulties that Kant himself comes to underscore by speaking of space as a *given* infinity.<sup>87</sup>

The demonstration by which Kant seeks to establish space and time as subjective forms of intuition consists partly in direct analysis, partly in an apagogic proof. For the sake of brevity I speak in the following only of space, since Kant's reasoning for time runs quite parallel to his reasoning about space.

Space is a *form of intuition*, because it presents to us a whole that becomes conscious to us by successive grasping-together of the parts, by synthesis. A concept of the understanding, by contrast, shows us merely the composition of the whole as *conditioned* by the parts, without showing us its coming-into-being. For intuition the individual part is conditioned by the whole, for the understanding conversely (Diss. § 1; 15 Coroll.). — *If*,

---

<sup>85</sup>See also *Metaphysische Anfangsgründe der Naturwissenschaft*. Riga 1786. p. 7 f.

<sup>86</sup>See on this Benno Erdmann in «Reflexionen Kants». II. p. 104 f. (the note).

<sup>87</sup>See on this B. Erdmann in «Reflexionen Kants». II. p. 110 f. (the note). — Kant himself has, in a treatise directed against Kästner, which was first brought forward by Dilthey in *Archiv für Gesch. der Phil.* III (p. 83 ff.), sought to clarify this point.

on the other hand, space were not a form of intuition but a concept of the understanding, *then* the concepts of continuity and infinity *would* enclose a contradiction, which falls away when one supports them on intuition's constant and in principle unceasing advance from part to part (Diss. § 1; 2, III).

A double demonstration — a direct and an apagogic — is also employed to establish that space is only a *subjective* mode of apprehension.

If we apprehend space as a subjective schema in which we order the sensations that arise in us (*schema coordinandi*), then the laws of space must also hold for all material phenomena. For everything we are to be able to apprehend must become an object for the ordering mental activity (*vis animi, omnes sensationes coordinans*). The laws of sense-intuition must therefore necessarily be the laws of nature, and the application of geometry in natural science is thereby explained: the same intuition from which geometry springs we use, after all, every time we apprehend something by means of the outer sense. The validity of applied geometry is then a simple inference from the subjectivity of the form of space (Diss. § 15 C. and E.). — On the other hand: «If the concept of space were not originally given by means of the nature of consciousness, *then* the application of geometry in natural science *would* be uncertain; for doubt might then be raised as to how far this very concept, drawn from experience, agreed with nature» (Diss. § 15 E.).

Kant's demonstration is of interest, since it shows us how direct analysis and antinomic trains of inference go hand in hand. After he has found by analysis that space is a synthetic form of intuition, he shows that another assumption would lead to absurdities. And as he then passes over to drawing the further inferences from what he has thus established, he investigates the two possibilities: that space is subjective, and that it is not subjective, and shows that the consequences of both lead to the same result, namely that the possibility of applied mathematics is bound to the subjectivity of the forms of intuition. We find here the conclusion of the long series of analyses and antinomies through which Kant has worked his way forward to the decisive principle for his theory of knowledge.

This principle we may, employing the well-known comparison in the preface to the 2nd edition of the «Kritik der reinen Vernunft», call *the Copernican principle*. It states that our knowledge of existence is determined by a nature of knowledge, and that we, when we know its laws, can decide beforehand which general laws the phenomena must be subject to. — This principle did not — which cannot surprise — dawn on Kant at once in its full range. In the Dissertation it is applied only to sense-intuition, not

to the understanding. While sense-intuition thus shows us things only as phenomena, that is, as they appear to our apprehension, which clothes them in the forms of our grasping intuition, the understanding is still, in its pure concepts (substance, cause, possibility, actuality, necessity, etc.), to be able to lead to a knowledge of things in themselves, of the inner essence of existence. It had, by Kant's own statement, cost him long reflection to establish the difference between intuition and understanding, which dogmatic philosophy had effaced. It was then no wonder that he could believe that these two different branches of our faculty of knowledge were subject to different conditions, so that subjectivity and the restriction to phenomena held only for intuition, not for the understanding. The venerable distinction, deriving from Plato, between *Phænomena* and *Noumena*, to which he had now been led along his own path,<sup>88</sup> was bound, for him, quite naturally to correspond to the difference between intuition and understanding. There is, however, nothing new in the knowledge of noumena that he still regards as possible along the path of thinking. It consists essentially in the thought, familiar from «Beweisgrund» and earlier works, of existence's unitary ground as the necessary condition for the law-governed interaction in nature. (See above § 4.) The Dissertation thereby hangs together continuously with Kant's earlier train of thought, while at the same time, by its Copernican principle, it points forward toward «Kritik der reinen Vernunft».

*Friederich Paulsen*, who places the awakening in 1769, conceives the Dissertation as a reaction, brought about by Hume's influence, against the sceptical tendencies of the preceding years. I believe that he sets it in too great opposition to the immediately preceding period. Kant had never given up the hope of a concluding result along the path of thinking, though its fulfilment was deferred to an indeterminate future. He had even, in his most sceptical writing, declared himself in love with metaphysics, and in a contemporary letter stated that it was merely a matter of divesting metaphysics of its dogmatic garb. It is psychologically understandable that he, after the discovery of the difference between intuition and understanding and of the Copernican principle in its application to sense-knowledge, could believe himself near the goal. For a moment he believed he had reached the definitive determination of limits that he had sought after for several years. Add to this that the knowledge of noumena which Kant at this stage regards

---

<sup>88</sup>The expression «intelligible world» is already found in «Träume» (1. Th. 2. Hauptst.), where it is used of the «mystical philosophy's» world of spiritual substances, evidently with a view to *Leibniz's* world of monads. *Leibniz* himself used the expression *mundus intelligibilis* of the world of monads (*Epistola ad Hanschium*. Op. phil. ed. Erdmann, p. 445 C.), or, what comes to the same, of the world of purposes (*Animadv. in Principia Cartesiana*. Phil. Schr. ed. Gerhardt. IV, p. 391). — B. *Erdmann* and R. *Riedel* have shown, what is fully confirmed by the «Reflexionen», that Kant's intelligible world is *Leibniz's* world of monads with due modification.

as possible is yet only symbolic, since all data of intuition are lacking. However strictly Kant distinguishes between intuition and understanding, he nevertheless impresses already now (Diss. § 10) that all material for our knowledge is obtained by sensation. And the concepts of the understanding are conceived no less than the forms of intuition as an expression of the nature of the knowing mental activity (Ibid. § 8). This is rather a limitation of the noumenal knowledge than an extension of it.

26. What Kant lacked in order to reach his definitive standpoint was the carrying-through of the Copernican principle on *all* the first presuppositions for our knowledge, and thereby the extension of phenomenalism to hold for all scientific knowledge of existence. It might seem as if there were not far to go, since the first step, the one that usually costs the most, had already been taken with the grounding of the critical doctrine of space and time. But it nevertheless cost Kant eleven years' work to take the step all the way. A sign of the man's great conscientiousness, and at the same time a testimony to how highly different the matter stands for the thinker stuck in the midst of the problems and for the retrospective historian. It can already on practical grounds be understood that Kant shrank from definitively excluding knowledge from the thing in itself. The carrying-through of phenomenalism became possible for him only when his ethical theory had developed in such a way that in the ethical basic fact he could see a possibility of access to the world that was now closed off for theoretical knowledge. The «unconditioned» that he could no longer accommodate in knowledge he had to find a place for in faith; only then did he regard his task as solved, in that he had found «practical data» for a concept he could not give up, but whose theoretical data he had dissolved.<sup>89</sup> The chief difficulty has, however, as is seen from the «Reflexionen», been theoretical. It was, after all, a matter of finding a point of view for the activity of the understanding by which what had been shown for sense-intuition could also come to hold for it, despite the difference so strongly emphasised in the Dissertation.

Yet the proper Kantian philosophy came into being with the Dissertation. So Kant himself conceived it, when he (in the letters to Garve and Mendelssohn) declared «Kritik der reinen Vernunft» to be the fruit of twelve years' work, and when he set the year 1770 as the limit for the writings he wished reprinted. (See above § 1.) I cannot see that the assumption maintained by *Benno Erdmann*, that the awakening first took place in the middle of the 1770s, is compatible with this. It was, after all, a matter in these years of carrying through an already found principle, a principle that in itself presupposes a

---

<sup>89</sup>See on this *Kritik der reinen Vernunft*. 2nd ed. p. XIX–XXII, where these «practical data» are regarded as a verification of «the Copernican principle», just as Newton's law of gravitation gave a verification of Copernicus' astronomy.

break with dogmatism. Kant cannot, when in 1783 he wrote the well-known lines in the preface to the *Prolegomena* that were to cause Kant scholars so much head-scratching, have wished to divide into two sharply separated parts *that* period which he otherwise regarded as a whole. The definitive closing of access to the things in themselves is, to be sure, an epoch-making event. But the expression awakening does not fit it, whereas it does fit a change in the manner of inquiry, which brought about that closing as its final result.

27. In the Dissertation a distinction is drawn between a merely logical use of the understanding, which consists in comparison, the demonstration of identity and difference, and a real use, which is not more closely characterised, but which is to have absolute validity, not merely validity for the phenomena, whereas the logical use is merely to serve the ordering of the phenomena. The work of thought that lies between the Dissertation and «*Kritik der reinen Vernunft*» aims at a closer investigation of how matters stand with this «real use».<sup>90</sup> The problem posed itself (as is seen from Kant's letters to Lambert and Hertz) immediately after the publication of the Dissertation. When the concepts of the understanding or «intellectual representations» that we use to penetrate, along the path of thinking, into the essence of things, express our mind's mode of operation, how can they then be shown to have validity for existence itself? Or as it is said in the letter to Hertz of 21 February 1772: «When such intellectual representations [Diss. § 8 names: the concepts possibility, actuality, necessity, substance, cause] rest on our inner activity, whence then comes the agreement that they are to have with objects, which after all are not produced by them, and how do the principles of pure reason about the objects agree with these, when this agreement may not seek support in experience?»

As guidance in this investigation Kant had the discovery from the Dissertation. There can, as regards the mathematical fundamental relations, be given an a priori knowledge of sensible nature, because the mathematical fundamental concepts express the laws for the synthetic construction that displays itself in every sense-intuition. Now it is clear that so long as Kant held fast his earlier so strongly maintained conception of thinking as analysis, the real use of the understanding had to stand as a riddle. It had in its time advanced Kant a great step that he so definitely impressed that all judging was a comparison. (The treatise on false subtlety.) Now it was a matter of gaining a deeper-reaching conception of the activity of the understanding, so that this could offer an agreement with sense-intuition. To regard the understanding straightforwardly as an intuition would lead to mysticism. What way out, then, was to be found?

---

<sup>90</sup>The expression «real use of reason», in opposition to the merely logical use, also occurs in «*Kritik der reinen Vernunft*», at least in the Dialectic. (2nd ed. p. 355.)

In the «Reflexionen» and in the «loose leaves» one can see how diligently Kant worked with the various fundamental concepts that constituted the content of the earlier ontology, before he got this so-called science transformed into «the analytic of the understanding». It was first a matter of tracing them back to certain main concepts, in order then in these to find expression for definite kinds of activity of the understanding. Already in the cited letter to Hertz he mentions his effort «to trace all the concepts of absolutely pure reason back to a certain number of categories, in such a way that their division into classes is determined by a few fundamental laws holding for the understanding». Here there were two paths to go. One could proceed from an analysis of the fundamental concepts that the understanding operates with, in order to find the laws for the understanding's activity, or one could seek directly to determine the law for the understanding's activity, in order then thereby in turn to find which main kinds of fundamental concepts it applies, according to its nature, to the given material. Kant has, as it seems, gone both ways.

First he tried his way with various combinations and divisions of the «ontological» concepts. He has, for example, dwelt on the concepts comparison, connection, and relation (or connection), and he has particularly investigated the concepts connection and comparison and found that by both the operations they express a unity is brought about or established: «All unity is either the unity of comparison or of connection. The first we have insofar as something is of the same kind as something else; the second insofar as a manifold is connected in one ground.»<sup>91</sup> He has investigated the concepts substance, cause, and interaction, which evidently particularly interested him. And here too it was the concept of a unity in the manifold, brought about by the form of thought, that he particularly noted: «The concept of substance and accident itself contains a synthesis, likewise cause and effect, and manifoldness in real unity [i.e. interaction]. According to its various relations to the inner sense, nature must now necessarily stand under one of these syntheses.»<sup>92</sup> The concept synthesis he seems first to have applied only to these three relations, which he early gathered under the expression relation. Thus it is said in a note that precedes the genesis of the proper doctrine of categories: «Only for the relation do objectively synthetic propositions about the phenomena hold.»<sup>93</sup>

---

<sup>91</sup>*Reflexionen Kants*. II. p. 143 (No. 461). Cf. p. 164 (Nos. 525 ff.).

<sup>92</sup>*Lose Blätter*. I. p. 18 f. Cf. *Reflexionen Kants*. II. p. 174–181 (Nos. 562–587).

<sup>93</sup>*Lose Blätter*. I. p. 17. — The expression relation Kant has probably taken from the Aristotelian table of categories. He applied it to the above-mentioned group of categories before he used it to designate a class of judgments. See on this *Adickes: Kants Systematik als systembildender Faktor*. Berlin 1887. p. 26; 36. — Perhaps he was, by the concept of relation, led to fix his attention on the judgments. Cf. Refl. No. 532: «Our reason contains nothing but relations». No. 596: «*The category of relation (consciousness-unity) is the most important of all. For unity really concerns only relation. Thus this constitutes the content of the*

It cannot (according to what has been developed in the first chapter of this treatise) surprise us that it was particularly this class of categories that led Kant to extend the concept synthesis to the activity of the understanding and thereby also to discover that the Copernican principle had also to hold for this. — Already in the beginning of the Dissertation he had intimated, as a common point of view for all our knowledge, that it partly forms a whole out of given elements, partly dissolves given wholes into their elements. Thereby arise two limit-concepts: the absolutely simple (*simplex* i.e. *pars quæ non est totum*) and the world-totality (*mundus* i.e. *totum quod non est pars*). Here, then, reference was made to the two fundamental mental operations, synthesis and analysis, and the question was bound to present itself, which of them was the more primitive. In the Dissertation it was now established, as regards intuition, that it rested on synthesis. The great advance that Kant made in the psychology of knowledge in the course of the 1770s was then the discovery that not only all intuiting, but also all thinking consists in synthesis, when one goes back to the fundamental form of the activity of thought, and that analysis is always secondary in relation to it, since one can only dissolve what is already connected. It dawned on Kant that not only the ordering in space and time, but also the inner connection among the phenomena which our knowledge brings about, is due to a «linking-together» (*Verkettung*) of representations, an inner act of consciousness which first brings a real whole out of the given elements. Without such an act of consciousness no experience; thus it must have universal validity.<sup>94</sup>

The Copernican principle stood, so far as one can see, firm for Kant in its full extent as soon as he had, by investigation of the categories, found synthesis as the common determination of all cognitive activity. Our mind, our self, then came to stand as an archetype or prototype for all objects that we are to know. (See above § 5 concl.; 12; 15.)

But investigation of the current ontological fundamental concepts and demonstration of their origin from a synthetic mental activity was not the only path by which Kant came to his doctrine of categories. It was for him only a provisional method, which did not satisfy him, because it was too empirical. It contained no guarantee that *all* the fundamental concepts had been found. And for Kant it was a chief matter that the limits of knowledge could be marked out a priori, after a complete investigation of all the fundamental forms of knowledge. This he believed he could attain by laying the doctrine of judgments at the foundation, in such a way that to every particular kind of judgment there corresponds a certain definite category. But before he struck out upon this path, which as is known led him to encumber his presentation with a

---

*judgments in general and lets itself alone be thought as determined a priori».*

<sup>94</sup>*Lose Blätter*. I. p. 16.

great scholastic scaffolding, the general idea of the activity of the understanding as synthesis had clearly enough stood clear for him. This is seen from what has been cited above from the «loose leaves», and the «Reflexionen» also establish it. Thus when it is said (Refl. No. 600): «The judgment is the unity of consciousness of the manifold in the representation of an object in general. The category is the representation of an object in general, insofar as it is determined with respect to this objective unity of consciousness». Here the concept synthesis lies at the foundation for the definition of the judgment. It must have been found as a fundamental concept before it could be seen that all judging falls under it. The presentation in «Kritik der reinen Vernunft» testifies to the same. Here the understanding is first determined as the faculty of knowing by means of concepts. A knowledge by concepts is discursive, thus presupposes a mental function, and a function means «the unity of the act of ordering various representations under a common representation» [cf. the Dissertation's *vis coordinandi*]. Of his concepts the understanding can now make use only by judging, that is, determining the representation of an object by another representation; it is only intuition that has immediately to do with the object. The functions of the understanding can be completely found when one can completely present the various ways in which unity of various representations is expressed in the judgments.<sup>95</sup> And this Kant now believes himself able to accomplish by an «improved» edition of the current logical doctrine of judgments.<sup>96</sup> On this I shall not enter more closely. As significant as Kant's general thought about the activity of the understanding as judging and about the judgment as synthesis is, just as arbitrary is the application in detail, although his great genius shows itself here too in many valuable thoughts to which he finds room within the scholastic frame. Had Kant, instead of laying so much weight on deducing a complete system of categories and principles, held fast to the general thought that the logical principles that condition the formal validity of the judgments must also hold for all experience, for all connection among phenomena that is to come into being for us, then he would have avoided much obscurity and arbitrariness, and the transcendental analytic, as the doctrine of *the possibility of applied logic*, would then have been placed in an instructive manner alongside the «transcendental aesthetic» as the doctrine of *the possibility of applied mathematics*.

28. The «subjective deduction» (that is, the derivation, supported on psychological analysis, of the nature of the faculty of knowledge), by which Kant arrived at determining synthesis as the fundamental form of knowledge and at giving a survey of the special

<sup>95</sup>*Kritik der reinen Vernunft*. 1st ed. p. 67–69 (Von dem logischen Verstandesgebrauche überhaupt).

<sup>96</sup>On the manner in which Kant, for his «transcendental» use, has altered the system of judgments, see Adickes: *Kants Systematik*, p. 30–41.

forms in which it displays itself, was for him nevertheless not the chief matter. His chief task was by contrast the objective or transcendental deduction, the demonstration of the validity and limits of rational knowledge. To this the analytic investigation of the forms forms only introduction and foundation. It was, as he wrote to Garve (7 August 1783), his task to ground «an entirely new and hitherto unattempted science, namely the critique of an a priori judging reason», which «from the mere concept of a faculty of knowledge (when it is exactly determined) derives a priori all objects, everything one can know about them, indeed even what one involuntarily, though wrongly, is compelled to judge about them». With justice he complained that he was so grossly misunderstood on this point in the first assessment of his principal work, and this had as a consequence that the psychological analysis stepped more into the background in his later presentations. (See above § 13.) The attractive thing about the first edition of «Kritik der reinen Vernunft» consists precisely in the freshness and fullness with which the concept of synthesis is presented in its significance for the cognitive functions, all the way from sense-intuition to the highest act of thought. It is a question whether this presentation, which in the 2nd edition is considerably abbreviated, is not the part of Kant's doctrine that is most penetrating and has the most enduring value. As so often, it is not the conscious chief aim, but the subordinate aims, which one had to set oneself in order to reach the former, that have proved to be of greatest importance.

The significance of Kant's concept of synthesis is, in the first place, that he thereby shows us *what it is to understand a thing*. His doctrine of knowledge rests on the simple thought that to understand something is to see it in as close a connection as possible with everything else we know. A connecting mental activity must make itself felt in all knowledge; only when we can apply it have we appropriated the given material and feel the peculiar satisfaction that accompanies the relieving of a need. What we do not understand is the isolated and the connectionless. Naturally there are many degrees between the two extremes: to understand and not to understand, connection and connectionlessness, and, as we have seen (above § 14–15), Kant committed the error of not attending to these differences of degree. But the merit he has is to have been the first to see the problem of knowledge in this simple way. It is a Columbus' egg that he has found and stood on its end. Remarkably enough *Hume* had found the same Columbus' egg, but let it roll away from him. In his «Treatise» (which Kant did not know) Hume really came to the same fundamental concept that Kant reached in «Kritik der reinen Vernunft». For Hume there traced the problem of knowledge from the special problems (particularly the problem of the real validity of geometry and of

the causal relation) back to the fundamental difficulty which for him — on account of the atomistic psychology from which he proceeded — lay in the connection among representations as a whole. The great riddle lay for him at last in the principle of unity (*the uniting principle*).<sup>97</sup> Kant now shows that the difference between the intelligible and the enigmatic rests on the difference between what can be grasped together in continuous connection and that where such a function is not possible. The connecting function itself one can then plainly only find enigmatic, either when one proceeds from the assumption that the connectionless should be the intelligible, or when one asks about the greater connection by which our grasping function is in turn conditioned. The first path leads out into the meaningless; the other path leads to posing for us the last problem that the theory of knowledge and psychology as a whole can stand before, and which marks their limit: namely, of the arising of knowledge itself, or of consciousness as a whole, in existence. Thought is to itself its own last problem.<sup>98</sup> — It would surely have been of great importance for Kant's development if he had known Hume's principal work at an early stage of his career. The collision between the two great thinkers would then have concerned a still more central question, and Kant would perhaps have been led to a complete working-through of the psychological foundation for his theory of knowledge, while on the other hand he would have been able to spare himself a long scholastic labour. The egg would earlier and more easily have been stood on its end. It was, for the subsequent history of philosophy, a fateful act that Hume committed when he, dissatisfied with the slight literary fortune that his youthful work had and vexed at the inopportune attacks to which it was subject from the theological side, disowned this magnificent work of his.<sup>99</sup>

While Kant by his diligent work of thought found the fundamental concept that could lead beyond the atomistic psychology that lay at the foundation of empiricism, he had by the same fundamental concept attained a conception of the essence of mind that led beyond the surreptitious concepts of the spiritualist dogmatism (cf. above § 8). Over against empiricism, which would regard the unity of mind as a mere result of the manifold impressions, he maintains the unitary activity as the fundamental stamp

---

<sup>97</sup> *Treatise of human nature*. I, 3, 14 (ed. Selby-Bigge. Oxford 1888. p. 169). Cf. Appendix (ibid. p. 636).

<sup>98</sup> Cf. my *Psychology*. 3rd ed. p. 403.

<sup>99</sup> *Eduard Grimm (Zur Geschichte des Erkenntnisproblems*. Leipzig 1890. p. 584) sees in this disowning an admission on Hume's part of the one-sidedness in the «Treatise». But that the motive was decidedly the one brought forward above is clearly seen partly from Hume's autobiography, partly from the letter in which Hume urged his publisher to let the declaration in which he disowned the «Treatise» accompany the «Inquiry». *Letters of David Hume to William Strahan*. Edited by C. Birkbeck Hill. Oxford 1888. p. 288 f. — It was also for the last-mentioned reason that Hume did not let the «Dialogues» appear in his lifetime. Ibid. p. 330.

of spiritual life, which cannot be explained by external influence alone; over against spiritualism, which has indeed an eye for this fundamental stamp, but dogmatically will trace it back to a mystical substance behind consciousness, he maintains (in his critique of rational psychology) that from the function one has no right to infer the substance, and that this inference in any case cannot lead to real knowledge.<sup>100</sup> Kant's concept of synthesis expresses the fundamental form and fundamental law for spiritual life, so far as we can know it along the path of experience. He has thereby given psychology an important point of view, a measure in the valuation of the development of spiritual life, — and at the same time some of its most important problems, for the spiritual unity is often threatened by the manifoldness and conflict of the elements. It is especially interesting to see how high Kant, by this concept, raises himself above the Enlightenment's emphasis on the clearly conscious and intellectually seen-through. For synthesis lies indeed at the foundation of consciousness, but need not be noticed by consciousness itself. It is consciousness's constant condition, but not necessarily its object. It works blindly, instinctively in our innermost essence. When Kant in «Kritik der Urtheilskraft» (§ 46) defines genius as «the innate mental endowment by which nature gives rules to art», then it is only a special application of something that holds for all conscious life. There is, if one will, something of genius in every conscious being, which in those who are especially to be called geniuses only steps forth in the highest potency. — The immediate and involuntary in spiritual life is thus, by the Kantian conception, maintained in its right and significance as the constant foundation. Kant's concept of synthesis has a far more comprehensive significance than the one he ascribes to it in his theory of knowledge, and it has in any case more enduring worth than other components of his philosophy which he himself rated ever so highly.

---

<sup>100</sup> *Leibniz* is the one of the dogmatic philosophers who comes closest to the concept of synthesis, as when he (Monadologie § 14) defines «perception» thus: *l'état passager qui enveloppe et représente une multitude dans l'unité ou dans la substance simple*. — Leibniz reproached the Cartesians for not defining what they understood by thinking (i.e. consciousness). His own definition was that consciousness is manifoldness expressed in a unity. (Philos. Schr. ed. Gerhardt. VII. p. 551). «*Les ames sont des unités et les corps sont des multitudes, mais les unités ne laissent de représenter les multitudes ... C'est dans cette réunion que consiste la nature admirable du sentiment.*» (ibid. p. 542.)